

BIG TEN PREVIEW

PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	OHIO STATE BUCKEYES
	2	INDIANA HOOSIERS
	3	OREGON DUCKS
	4	MICHIGAN WOLVERINES
	5	USC TROJANS
	6	WASHINGTON HUSKIES
	7	PENN STATE NITTANY LIONS
	8	IOWA HAWKEYES
	9	ILLINOIS FIGHTING ILLINI
	10	NEBRASKA CORNHUSKERS
	11	MINNESOTA GOLDEN GOPHERS
	12	UCLA BRUINS
	13	WISCONSIN BADGERS
	14	NORTHWESTERN WILDCATS
	15	MARYLAND TERRAPINS
	16	RUTGERS SCARLET KNIGHTS
	17	MICHIGAN STATE SPARTANS
	18	PURDUE BOILERMAKERS

BIG TEN CHAMPIONSHIP

OHIO STATE OVER INDIANA



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSPORTS.COM FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-BIG TEN TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	JULIAN SAYIN	Ohio State
RB	BO JACKSON	Ohio State
RB	JORDAN MARSHALL	Michigan
AP	ANTWAN RAYMOND	Rutgers
WR	JEREMIAH SMITH	Ohio State
WR	CHARLIE BECKER	Indiana
WR	KJ DUFF	Rutgers
TE	JAMARI JOHNSON	Oregon
C	IAPANI LALOULU	Oregon
OL	CARTER SMITH	Indiana
OL	KADE PIEPER	Iowa
OL	TREVOR LAUCK	Iowa
OL	AUSTIN SIEREVELD	Ohio State

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	ANTHONY SMITH	Minnesota
DL	TYRIQUE TUCKER	Indiana
DL	JOHN HENRY DALEY	Michigan
DL	A'MAURI WASHINGTON	Oregon
LB	ROLIJAH HARDY	Indiana
LB	TEITUM TUIOTI	Oregon
LB	ISAIAH JONES	Indiana
LB	DANIEL WINGATE	Maryland
CB	BRANDON FINNEY JR.	Oregon
CB	JYAIRE HILL	Michigan
S	KOI PERICH	Oregon
S	AMARE FERRELL	Indiana

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	NICO RADICIC	Indiana
P	BRYCE McFERSON	Maryland
KR	KOI PERICH	Oregon
PR	JACORY BARNEY JR.	Nebraska

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Rate: Illinois vs. TCU

Pinstripe: Minnesota vs. Pitt

Music City: Nebraska vs. South Carolina

Reliaquest: Penn State vs. Florida

Citrus: Michigan vs. Ole Miss

Las Vegas: Iowa vs. Arizona

Holiday: Washington vs. Clemson

College Football Playoff First Round: Indiana vs. Boise State

College Football Playoff First Round: Oregon vs. Texas Tech

Fiesta (CFP Quarterfinals): Indiana vs. Notre Dame

Cotton (CFP Quarterfinals): Oregon vs. Texas

Rose (CFP Quarterfinals): Ohio State vs. Oklahoma

Orange (CFP Semifinals): Ohio State vs. Notre Dame

National Championship: Ohio State vs. Georgia

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

ILLINOIS

Defense: New: Bobby Hauck

Old: Aaron Henry

INDIANA

Offense: New: Mike Shanahan, Tino Sunseri;

Old: Mike Shanahan, Chandler Whitmer

MARYLAND

Offense: New: Clint Trickett

Old: Pep Hamilton

MICHIGAN

Offense: New: Jason Beck; Old: Chip Lindsey

Defense: New: Jay Hill; Old: Wink Martindale

MICHIGAN STATE

Offense: New: Nick Sheridan

Old: Brian Lindgren

Defense: New: Joe Rossi, Max Bullough

Old: Joe Rossi

NEBRASKA

Defense: New: Rob Aurich; Old: John Butler

NORTHWESTERN

Offense: New: Chip Kelly; Old: Zach Lujan

OHIO STATE

Offense: New: Arthur Smith, Keenan Bailey

Old: Brian Hartline, Keenan Bailey

OREGON

Offense: New: Drew Mehringer

Old: Will Stein

Defense: New: Chris Hampton

Old: Tosh Lupoi, Chris Hampton

PENN STATE

Offense: New: Taylor Mouser

Old: Andy Kotelnicki

Defense: New: D'Anton Lynn

Old: Jim Knowles

PURDUE

Defense: New: Kevin Kane; Old: Mike Scherer

RUTGERS

Defense: New: Travis Johansen

Old: Robb Smith, Zach Sparber

UCLA

Offense: New: Dean Kennedy

Old: Jerry Neuheisel (interim)

Defense: New: Colin Hitschler

Old: Ikaika Malloe

USC

Defense: New: Gary Patterson

Old: D'Anton Lynn

WASHINGTON

Offense: New: Jedd Fisch

Old: Jimmie Dougherty

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Luke Wafle	EDGE	USC	★★★★★	1
2. Zion Elee	EDGE	Maryland	★★★★★	6
3. Jaimeon Winfield	DL	USC	★★★★★	11
4. Jay Timmons	CB	Ohio State	★★★★★	12
5. Savion Hiter	RB	Michigan	★★★★★	13

JEREMIAH SMITH, OHIO STATE
JOSH HOOVER, INDIANA



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Josh Hoover	QB	Indiana	TCU
Hoover joins forces with QB whisperer Curt Cignetti with 31 starts to his name.			
2. John Henry Daley	DL	Michigan	Utah
A torn Achilles cut Daley's breakout season short. He'll be a force up front.			
3. Nick Marsh	WR	Indiana	Michigan State
Marsh is a top-tier talent ready to realize his potential in a reliable passing game.			
4. Koi Perich	S	Oregon	Minnesota
Perich is a versatile replacement for Dillon Thieneman and doubles as a kick returner.			
5. Rocco Becht	QB	Penn State	Iowa State
Becht's 39 starts and big-game experience will ease his transition to the Big Ten.			
6. Colton Joseph	QB	Wisconsin	Old Dominion
Joseph is one of only four returning signal-callers who ran for 1,000 yards in 2025.			
7. James Smith	DL	Ohio State	Alabama
A big-bodied disruptor among the latest group to join the Buckeyes from Bama.			
8. Tobi Osunsanmi	DL	Indiana	Kansas State
Osunsanmi's pass-rushing prowess addresses an area of need after NFL departures.			
9. Anthony Colandrea	QB	Nebraska	UNLV
The Mountain West Offensive Player of the Year is on the move again.			
10. Katin Houser	QB	Illinois	East Carolina
Back in the Big Ten on the heels of a career year as both a passer and a runner.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. USC (2)	7. Indiana (20)	13. Maryland (51)
2. Ohio State (4)	8. Minnesota (23)	14. Northwestern (52)
3. Oregon (6)	9. Illinois (28)	15. Penn State (58)
4. Michigan (11)	10. Rutgers (37)	16. UCLA (64)
5. Washington (14)	11. Purdue (48)	17. Wisconsin (71)
6. Iowa (18)	12. Michigan State (49)	18. Nebraska (123)

Rankings per Rivals; National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 12	Ohio State at Texas	Oct. 31	Ohio State at USC
Sept. 12	Oklahoma at Michigan	Nov. 7	Oregon at Ohio State
Sept. 26	Oregon at USC	Nov. 14	USC at Indiana
Oct. 17	Ohio State at Indiana	Nov. 14	Michigan at Oregon
Oct. 17	Penn State at Michigan	Nov. 28	Michigan at Ohio State
Oct. 24	Indiana at Michigan	Nov. 28	Washington at Oregon

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Jalen Lott	WR	Oregon	★★★★★	14
7. Carter Meadows	EDGE	Michigan	★★★★★	16
8. Jerquaden Guilford	WR	Ohio State	★★★★★	17
9. Immanuel Iheanacho	OT	Oregon	★★★★★	21
10. Khary Wilder	EDGE	Ohio State	★★★★★	22

Rankings per Rivals; +Consensus 5-star prospect



ILLINOIS FIGHTING ILLINI

NATIONAL FORECAST: 33 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 9 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 5-4 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Head coach Bret Bielema found a replacement for three-year starting quarterback Luke Altmyer at East Carolina, where Katin Houser had two strong seasons after starting his career at Michigan State. Houser made a strong impression in the spring, winning over his new teammates with his talent and leadership.

Houser will be operating behind a mostly new offensive line. Guard Brandon Henderson is the lone returning starter. Line coach Bart Miller, who has been at Illinois since Bielema took over in Champaign, spent the spring trying to fit the pieces together. One big addition: former Wisconsin center Jake Renfro, the son of former Illinois offensive lineman Rick.

Tailback is set with the return of Aidan Laughery and Ca'Lil Valentine, who combined for 996 rushing yards and seven scores. The coaches felt good enough about the position to move Kaden Feagin to tight end, where he could have a major impact.

Hudson Clement and Collin Dixon, who caught 36 and 35 passes, respectively, in 2025, figure to be Houser's top targets.

DEFENSE When defensive coordinator Aaron Henry left for Notre Dame after the season, Bielema decided to take the unit in a totally different direction, hiring former FCS Montana head coach Bobby Hauck to install a 3-3-5 defensive scheme and show the Big Ten something new. Bielema is counting on the element of surprise to give his team a boost.

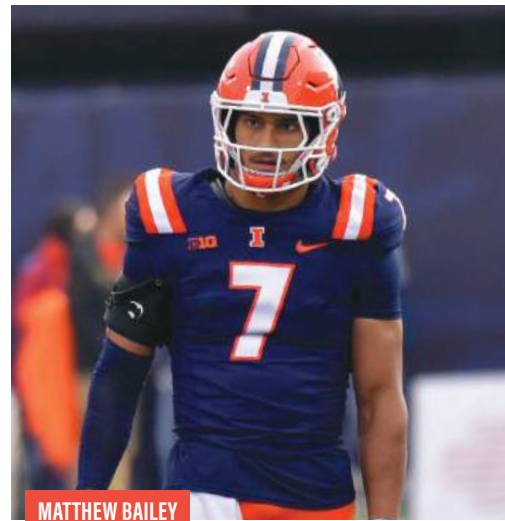
There's experience in the secondary, where safeties Matthew Bailey and Xavier Scott return. Bailey led the team with 76 tackles in 2025. Senior cornerback Juice Clarke should be an honors candidate.

Up front, Illinois is counting on veteran Pat Farrell, who learned from star pass-rusher Gabe Jacas last season. James Kreutz and Daniel Brown are the top returnees at linebacker.

SPECIALISTS David Olano won the Music City Bowl for Illinois with a late field goal against Tennessee, then got an offer he couldn't refuse and transferred to Texas A&M. Ethan Moczulski returned to Illinois after a season at Washington and will handle placekicking duties. Illinois added punter Lars Rau from Texas State.

FINAL ANALYSIS The 2024 and '25 Illinois football teams set the school record for wins in a two-year stretch with 19. What Bielema and his staff really want, though, is a spot in the College Football Playoff. The schedule includes a pair of preseason top-5 teams — Ohio State and Oregon — but every other game is winnable. Still, Illinois is one of the least-experienced teams in the country a year after being one of the most experienced. Another nine-win season is the likely best-case scenario.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 5-4 BIG TEN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 29	Western Illinois	W	52-3	Sept. 5	UAB	1. Nick Hankins Jr., CB	★★★★				
Sept. 6	at Duke	W	45-19	Sept. 12	Duke	2. Jacob Eberhart, LB	★★★★				
Sept. 13	Western Michigan	W	38-0	Sept. 19	Southern Illinois	3. Parker Crim, EDGE	★★★★				
Sept. 20	at Indiana	L	10-63	Sept. 26	at Ohio State	4. Champ Smith, IOL	★★★				
Sept. 27	USC	W	34-32	Oct. 3	Purdue	5. Almirian Thomas, CB	★★★				
Oct. 4	at Purdue	W	43-27	Oct. 10	at Michigan State	6. Kenyon Alston, WR	★★★				
Oct. 11	Ohio State	L	16-34	Oct. 24	Oregon	7. Nas Rankin, WR	★★★				
Oct. 25	at Washington	L	25-42	Oct. 31	at Maryland	8. Kai Pritchard, IOL	★★★				
Nov. 1	Rutgers	W	35-13	Nov. 7	Nebraska	9. Cameron Thomas, LB	★★★				
Nov. 15	Maryland	W	24-6	Nov. 14	at UCLA	10. Jakwon Morris, CB	★★★				
Nov. 22	at Wisconsin	L	10-27	Nov. 21	Iowa						
Nov. 29	Northwestern	W	20-13	Nov. 28	at Northwestern						
Dec. 30	vs. Tennessee #	W	30-28								
#Music City Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Bret Bielema • Record at School: 37-26 (5 years)											
Career Record: 134-84 (17 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Barry Lunney Jr.											
Defensive Coordinator: Bobby Hauck • Location: Champaign-Urbana, Ill.											
Stadium: Gies Memorial Stadium (60,670)											



MATTHEW BAILEY

SCOUTING THE ILLINI

"They evaluate great. They know what fits for them. They do a great job of not swinging for a home run every time they recruit only to lose guys to Ohio State in some one-on-one battle. They have no business doing that. They're super aware of that. They don't spend a lot of useless time, and they evaluate really well. It's not surprising in any aspect that they're this good. ... Their defensive line was outrageously good the last two years. In our evaluation, it was every bit as good as Penn State's, Michigan's and Ohio State's. But I know most of that group has left, so it'll be interesting to see who they replace them with."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	13	HUDSON CLEMENT (SR.)	11	Brayden Trimble (Fr.)
WR	9	Alex Perry* (Sr.)	7	Nas Rankin (Fr.)
WR	17	COLLIN DIXON (JR.)	10	Ty Robinson* (Sr.)
LT	72	Christian Martin* (Jr.)	74	Zafir Stewart (So.)
LG	66	Brandon Hansen (Jr.)	79	TJ Taylor (Jr.)
C	59	Jake Renfro* (Sr.)	55	TJ McMillen (Jr.)
RG	75	BRANDON HENDERSON (SR.)	78	Eddie Tuerk (So.)
RT	71	Nathan Knapik (So.)	70	Maika Matelau (So.)
TE	3	Kaden Feagin (Sr.)	86	Christian Abney (Sr.)
QB	4	Katin Houser* (Sr.)	2	Carson Boyd (Fr.)
RB	21	Aidan Laughery (Sr.)	5	Ca'Lil Valentine (Jr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	52	Pat Farrell (Jr.)	96	Darrell Prater* (Sr.)
NT	43	Joe Barna (Jr.)	24	Will Holmes* (Jr.)
DE	90	Carter Janki* (Sr.)	17	Isaiah Thomison* (Jr.)
LB	10	James Kreutz (Sr.)	26	Ismael Kante (Sr.)
LB	4	Daniel Brown (Sr.)	45	Robert Edmonson* (Jr.)
LB	33	Grant Beerman (So.)	23	Jaylen Stewart (Fr.)
CB	6	JUICE CLARKE (SR.)	3	Nick Hankins Jr. (Fr.)
CB	5	Jakwon Morris (Jr.)	22	Deuce Fillmore* (Sr.)
STAR	1	XAVIER SCOTT (SR.)	16	TANNER HECKEL (JR.)
S	0	Mac Resetich (Sr.)	14	Andre Lovett Jr. (So.)
S	7	MATTHEW BAILEY (SR.)	19	Jacob Eberhart (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	37	Ethan Moczulski* (Sr.)	KR	5	Ca'Lil Valentine (Jr.)
P	81	Lars Rau* (So.)	PR	1	Jayshon Platt* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

RON JOHNSON-IMAGI IMAGES



CHARLIE BECKER

SCOUTING THE HOOSIERS

"The biggest glaring thing is the production they lost in the receiver room. They've got some young guys coming in, and they paid a s— ton for [Michigan State transfer receiver] Nick Marsh, so we'll see how he does. They're just gonna be very young there. ... Defensively, they still return most of their production. But to me, it's hard to replicate what [Fernando] Mendoza did. [TCU transfer quarterback] Josh Hoover is a good player. I think he's got some turnover issues. But other than that, they reloaded. ... They're gonna lose that rush of James Madison guys that they had the last two years, so they could definitely struggle in some areas of continuity where maybe the talent does have to take over, but I'm definitely not gonna underestimate Indiana again."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	80	CHARLIE BECKER (JR.)	6	Lebron Bond (So.)
WR	11	Nick Marsh* (Jr.)	4	Davion Chandler (So.)
WR	8	Tyler Morris (Sr.)	7	Shazz Preston* (Sr.)
LT	65	CARTER SMITH (SR.)	61	Baylor Wilkin (Fr.)
LG	56	Joe Brunner* (Sr.)	66	Evan Parker (Fr.)
C	62	DREW EVANS (SR.)	70	Austin Leibfried (So.)
RG	74	BRAY LYNCH (SR.)	77	Matt Marek (Fr.)
RT	72	Adedamola Ajani (So.)	71	Ben Novak (Fr.)
TE	85	Andrew Barker (Fr.)	88	Brock Schott* (Fr.)
QB	10	Josh Hoover* (Sr.)	15	Tyler Cherry (Fr.)
RB	28	Khobie Martin (So.)	1	Turbo Richard* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	7	Chiddi Obiazor* (Jr.)	17	Daniel Ndukwe (Jr.)
DT	95	TYRIQUE TUCKER (SR.)	90	Joe Hjelle* (Sr.)
DT	97	MARIO LANDINO (JR.)	94	Kyler Garcia (Fr.)
DE	12	Tobi Osunsanmi* (Sr.)	8	Josh Burnham* (Sr.)
OLB	5	ROLIJAH HARDY (JR.)	14	Kaiden Turner (Sr.)
ILB	46	ISAIAH JONES (SR.)	34	Jeff Utzinger (Sr.)
CB	22	JAMARI SHARPE (SR.)	0	Carson Williams* (So.)
CB	4	AJ Harris* (Sr.)	10	Ryland Gandy (Sr.)
ROVER	2	Byron Baldwin Jr. (So.)	13	Quan Sanks* (Jr.)
S	1	AMARE FERRELL (SR.)	3	Jaylen Bell (So.)
S	6	Preston Zachman* (Sr.)	33	Garrett Reese (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	15	Nico Radicic (Jr.)	KR	29	Lee Beebe Jr. (Sr.)
P	93	Quinn Warren (Jr.)	PR	8	Tyler Morris (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



INDIANA HOOSIERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 5 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 16-0, 9-0 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Head coach Curt Cignetti follows the maxim of "production over potential" when it comes to transfers. Josh Hoover, the former TCU quarterback who'll replace Heisman Trophy winner Fernando Mendoza, is that adage come to life. Hoover is the most productive returning QB in the FBS with 9,629 passing yards and 71 touchdowns across 36 games (31 starts). He has a turnover issue that needs fixing and doesn't have the same stature as Mendoza — he's very generously listed at 6-foot-2 — but Hoover is the kind of heady player who will thrive in Cignetti's scheme.

He will also benefit from the tremendous amount of experience on the offensive line. The group features three returning starters, including reigning Big Ten Offensive Lineman of the Year Carter Smith at left tackle.

Wide receiver Charlie Becker closed out 2025 looking like one of the country's top playmakers and made a series of spectacular grabs that helped IU win the national title. He will line up next to Michigan State's former top receiver Nick Marsh to give IU a potent passing attack.

Sophomore running back Khobie Martin is one to watch as well. The reserve has waited his turn and looks primed to have a breakout season.

DEFENSE Indiana added one of the top defensive ends (Tobi Osunsanmi) and cornerbacks (AJ Harris) out of the portal while bringing back six starters, including a pair of starting defensive tackles (Tyrique Tucker and Mario Landino) and linebackers (Rolijah Hardy and Isaiah Jones).

It's an impressive mix of talent that will enable defensive coordinator Bryant Haines to create the same kind of havoc as he did last year. The Hoosiers had the second-most sacks in the FBS (46) and led the country in tackles for a loss (129) by mixing in stunts and twists up front, along with simulated pressures and disguises in the back end.

SPECIALISTS Indiana special teams units were the best in the country. Returning placekicker Nico Radicic has been a sneaky weapon, having gone 28-of-30 on field-goal attempts since 2024. IU has plenty of talented athletes — receivers Tyler Morris and Shazz Preston along with running back Lee Beebe Jr. — capable of making an impact in the return game.

FINAL ANALYSIS Cignetti's impeccable track record in Bloomington makes it easy to envision a path back to the postseason. While Indiana needs to replace its first-ever Heisman winner and a handful of James Madison transfers (Aiden Fisher, Elijah Sarratt and D'Angelo Ponds) who became household names in the Big Ten, Cignetti has been the best talent evaluator in college football in recent years. Behind the scenes, there's a high degree of confidence that IU has built a lasting winner.

2025 RESULTS (16-0, 9-0 BIG TEN)

Aug. 30	Old Dominion	W	27-14
Sept. 6	Kennesaw State	W	56-9
Sept. 12	Indiana State	W	73-0
Sept. 20	Illinois	W	63-10
Sept. 27	at Iowa	W	20-15
Oct. 11	at Oregon	W	30-20
Oct. 18	Michigan State	W	38-13
Oct. 25	UCLA	W	56-6
Nov. 1	at Maryland	W	55-10
Nov. 8	at Penn State	W	27-24
Nov. 15	Wisconsin	W	31-7
Nov. 28	at Purdue	W	56-3
Dec. 6	vs. Ohio State #	W	13-10
Jan. 1	vs. Alabama %	W	38-3
Jan. 9	vs. Oregon &	W	56-22
Jan. 19	vs. Miami (Fla.) \$	W	27-21

#Indianapolis %Rose Bowl: CFB Playoff Quarterfinal
&Peach Bowl: CFB Playoff Semifinal
\$Miami: CFB Playoff National Championship

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	North Texas
Sept. 12	Howard
Sept. 19	WKU
Sept. 26	Northwestern
Oct. 3	at Rutgers
Oct. 10	at Nebraska
Oct. 17	Ohio State
Oct. 24	at Michigan
Oct. 31	Minnesota
Nov. 14	USC
Nov. 21	at Washington
Nov. 28	Purdue

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Henry Ohlinger, ATH	★★★★
2. Gabe Hill, DL	★★★★
3. Parker Elmore, TE	★★★★
4. Kasmir Hicks, CB	★★★★
5. Ronelle Johnson, EDGE	★★★★
6. Ja'Dyn Williams, LB	★★★★
7. D'Montae Tims, S	★★★★
8. Kevontay Hugan, LB	★★★
9. Cam McHaney, DL	★★★
10. Trevor Gibbs, LB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Curt Cignetti • Record at School: 27-2 (2 years)
Career Record: 146-37 (15 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Mike Shanahan, Tino Sunseri • Defensive Coordinator: Bryant Haines • Location: Bloomington, Ind. • Stadium: Memorial Stadium (53,524)



IOWA HAWKEYES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 25 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-3 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Iowa added a program-record 16 players from the transfer portal, but none of them play quarterback. Head coach Kirk Ferentz seems to be saying that he believes he already has a capable successor to Mark Gronowski on the roster. Sophomore Jeremy Hecklinski and junior Hank Brown were in a hotly contested battle in the spring, with Hecklinski appearing to have a slight edge after having moved ahead of Brown on the depth chart about midway through the 2025 season. Neither played enough in 2025 to know how they would handle being the starter.

Iowa also has to replace three starters on the offensive line, all of whom made first-team All-Big Ten last season, including center Logan Jones, the 2025 Rimington Trophy winner as the nation's top center.

Three receivers arrived via the transfer portal, and Iowa has a rising star at tight end in sophomore and former walk-on DJ Vonnahme, who led the team with 434 receiving yards and three touchdown catches in 2025.

Kamari Moulton returns at running back after rushing for 878 yards and scoring five touchdowns last season.

DEFENSE Veteran defensive coordinator Phil Parker has eight starters to replace on defense, including all four on the defensive line. Parker is widely regarded as one of the top defensive coordinators in college football, and he will certainly have a chance to show why this fall.

Iowa loaded up in the transfer portal, adding four linemen and four defensive backs, including safety Tyler Brown from James Madison.

Junior Zach Lutmer is also poised to be Iowa's next great defensive back after earning second-team All-Big Ten honors last season. He has played safety, cornerback and the cash position, which is a cross between a linebacker and safety.

SPECIALISTS Iowa's placekicker, punter and All-America return specialist Kaden Wetjen all departed. The Hawkeyes also have a new special teams coordinator, with Chris Polizzi replacing the highly successful LeVar Woods, who is now the assistant head coach and special teams coordinator for Michigan State. Iowa turned to the transfer portal, landing placekicker Eli Ozick and two punters — Australia native Boston Everitt and Tanner Philpott. Replacing Wetjen could require a group effort.

FINAL ANALYSIS Iowa has typically been built to win anywhere from seven to 10 games under Ferentz, and this season appears to be no exception despite the loss of so many starters. If the quarterback position rises to the challenge, Parker continues to work his magic on defense and if the special teams do their part, Iowa could make some noise, but those are big "ifs."

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-3 BIG TEN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 UAlbany W 34-7	Sept. 5 Northern Illinois	1. Julian Manson, LB ★★★★★
Sept. 6 at Iowa State L 13-16	Sept. 12 Iowa State	2. Tradon Bessinger, QB ★★★★★
Sept. 13 Massachusetts W 47-7	Sept. 19 Northern Iowa	3. Darion Jones, CB ★★★★★
Sept. 19 at Rutgers W 38-28	Sept. 26 at Michigan	4. Kasen Thomas, LB ★★★★★
Sept. 27 Indiana L 15-20	Oct. 3 Ohio State	5. Hudson Parliament, IOL ★★★★★
Oct. 11 at Wisconsin W 37-0	Oct. 10 at Washington	6. Gene Riordan, IOL ★★★★★
Oct. 18 Penn State W 25-24	Oct. 24 at Minnesota	7. Carson Nielsen, OT ★★★★★
Oct. 25 Minnesota W 41-3	Oct. 31 Wisconsin	8. Owen Linder, OT ★★★★★
Nov. 8 Oregon L 16-18	Nov. 7 at Northwestern	9. Billy Weivoda, LB ★★★
Nov. 15 at USC L 21-26	Nov. 14 Purdue	10. Colin Whitters, IOL ★★
Nov. 22 Michigan State W 20-17	Nov. 21 at Illinois	
Nov. 28 at Nebraska W 40-16	Nov. 27 Nebraska	
Dec. 31 vs. Vanderbilt # W 34-27		
#Reliaquest Bowl		
	TEAM INFORMATION	
	Head Coach: Kirk Ferentz • Record at School: 213-128 (27 years)	
	Career Record: 225-149 (30 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Tim Lester	
	Defensive Coordinator: Phil Parker • Location: Iowa City, Iowa	
	Stadium: Kinnick Stadium (69,250)	



KAMARI MOULTON

SCOUTING THE HAWKEYES

"I heard that at Wake Forest, [former transfer quarterback] Jeremy Hecklinski struggled a bit there. Struggled to put on weight, struggled to buy into the intensity of college football a bit. I'm interested to see how he progresses at Iowa. ... It'll really be interesting to see with them the new philosophy of adding more transfers. What they've been doing has been working. It's been developmental, but in this day and age, you can't do that anymore. You have to adapt and make the right choices in the portal. I would still bet a lot of money that they're going to be really good, and the culture of their team will still be intact."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	2	Reece Vander Zee (Jr.)	0	Jarriett Buie (Jr.)
WR	14	Tony Diaz (So.)	8	Evan James* (So.)
WR	1	KJ Parker (So.)	7	Dayton Howard (Jr.)
LT	59	TREVOR LAUCK (JR.)	75	Cannon Leonard (Jr.)
LG	64	Leighton Jones (Jr.)	68	Will Nolan (So.)
C	58	KADE PIEPER (JR.)	61	Cael Winter (Jr.)
RG	53	Michael Myslinski (Sr.)	60	Lucas Allgeyer (Fr.)
RT	71	Jack Dotzler (Sr.)	65	Trent Wilson* (So.)
TE	81	DJ Vonnahme (So.)	48	Zach Ortwerth (Sr.)
QB	10	Jeremy Hecklinski (So.)	9	Hank Brown (Jr.)
RB	28	KAMARI MOULTON (JR.)	21	Lendon Phillips Jr.* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	97	Iose Epenesa (Fr.)	95	Lance Ingold* (So.)
DT	96	Bryce Hawthorne (Jr.)	51	Luke Gaffney (Sr.)
DT	92	Brice Stevenson* (Sr.)	91	Devan Kennedy (So.)
DE	44	Kenneth Merrieweather (Jr.)	43	Kahmari Brown* (Jr.)
LB	33	Cam Buffington (So.)	23	Landyn Van Kekerix (Sr.)
LB	36	JAYDEN MONTGOMERY (SR.)	22	Derek Weisskopf (So.)
CB	8	DESHAUN LEE (SR.)	11	Jacob Wallace (Fr.)
CB	7	Rashad Godfrey Jr. (So.)	3	Jaylen Watson (Jr.)
CASH	6	ZACH LUTMER (JR.)	19	Kyler Gerardy (So.)
S	5	Anthony Hawkins* (So.)	18	Xavier Styles* (So.)
S	2	Tyler Brown* (Jr.)	21	Marcello Vitti (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	25	Eli Ozick* (Jr.)	KR	3	Jaylen Watson (Jr.)
P	49	Boston Everitt* (Fr.)	PR	1	KJ Parker (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MALIK WASHINGTON

SCOUTING THE TERRAPINS

"They're hanging a lot on the quarterback [Malik Washington] and hoping that he repeats what he did as a freshman. I thought he was really impressive. I didn't think coming out of high school that he would be ready to do that. I know they lost eight straight, but he was not really the reason that they were losing. [Washington] is elite. He's a really good athlete, and we hit him a couple times, and it just didn't bother him. ... I think it'll be interesting how that whole thing stays together if they can be really productive on offense. I get the sense that they would like [head coach] Mike Locksley to work out. They're not trying to get rid of him, but it may just get to a point where they've gotta do what they've gotta do."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	84	Kaleb Webb (Sr.)	10	Zymear Smith (Fr.)
WR	1	Na'eem Abdul-Rahim Gladding* (Jr.)	14	Jordan Scott (Sr.)
WR	13	Chris Durr Jr.* (Jr.)	11	Ryan Manning (Jr.)
LT	76	RAHTEL PERRY (SR.)	73	Davon Watkins (So.)
LG	55	Tellek Lockette* (Sr.)	68	Carlos Moore (Sr.)
C	61	MICHAEL HERSHEY (JR.)	50	Trevor Szymanski (So.)
RG	71	Ryan Howerton (So.)	77	Amory Hills (So.)
RT	74	ISAIAH WRIGHT (SR.)	70	Jaylen Gilchrist (Fr.)
TE	9	DORIAN FLEMING (JR.)	8	Preston Howard* (Sr.)
QB	7	MALIK WASHINGTON (SO.)	22	Devin Kargman* (Jr.)
RB	0	DEJUAN WILLIAMS (SO.)	25	Harry Dalton III* (Fr.)

DEFENSE (8)

DE	11	SIDNEY STEWART (SO.)	56	DD Holmes (So.)
NT	98	EGAN THOMAS (JR.)	88	Derrick LeBlanc* (Jr.)
DT	99	Lavon Johnson (Sr.)	50	EJ Moore Jr. (Jr.)
DE	9	ZAHIR MATHIS (SO.)	40	Nahsir Taylor (So.)
OLB	0	Zion Elee (Fr.)	32	Carlton Smith (So.)
MLB	1	DANIEL WINGATE (SR.)	23	Keyshawn Flowers (Jr.)
ILB	3	TREY REDDICK (JR.)	35	Keyari James (So.)
CB	4	JAMARE GLASKER (SR.)	24	Amari Jackson* (Sr.)
CB	6	DONTAY JOYNER (SR.)	21	Judah Jenkins (So.)
SS	2	LAVAIN SCRUGGS (SR.)	7	Gavin Edwards (Jr.)
FS	33	Messiah Delhomme (So.)	5	Darrell Carey (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	36	Sean O'Haire (So.)	KR	24	Iverson Howard (So.)
P	34	Bryce McFerson (Sr.)	PR	25	Ricardo Cooper Jr. (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MARYLAND TERRAPINS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 58 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 15 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 1-8 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Quarterback Malik Washington started 12 games, setting freshman school records for completions and yards, and he'll do more to make Maryland go now. New offensive coordinator Clint Trickett wants the 6-foot-5, 231-pounder to run the ball more, direct a faster-paced offense with increased motion and get off more snaps.

Rushing leader DeJuan Williams (501 yards) is back, but the Terrapins were next-to-last in the Big Ten with 104.3 yards rushing yards per game. If the Terps are smart, they'll run behind Big Ten All-Academic center Michael Hershey and tackles Rahtrel Perry and Isaiah Wright, key figures in a line that allowed the fifth-fewest sacks per game nationally.

Last year's wide receiver group ranked among the national leaders in drops. Kaleb Webb is the top returning pass-catcher with 22 for a 14.5-yard average, but running back Williams (45 receptions) and tight end Dorian Fleming (40) caught more balls. Transfers Na'eem Abdul-Rahim Gladding (Old Dominion) and Chris Durr Jr. (Wyoming) should help.

DEFENSE With eight starters back in 2026, defensive coordinator Ted Monachino sees the unit taking a major step. One thing's for certain: They have an edge. In addition to Freshman All-America ends Sidney Stewart and Zahir Mathis, the unit is adding rusher extraordinaire Zion Elee, arguably the most highly touted Terp recruit ever.

Returning 300-pounders Lavon Johnson and Eyan Thomas make Maryland Big Ten-big in the middle, and coaches are talking about quality depth all over. Big-play linebacker Daniel Wingate, a two-year starter, and Trey Reddick, his partner in ball-carrier harm, are key vets.

Returning corners Dontay Joyner and Jamare Glasker are draft prospects, and Boston College transfer Amari Jackson joins the big-play fray. Safeties Lavain Scruggs and Messiah Delhomme look solid, and Darrell Carey could be the next big thing.

SPECIALISTS Sean O'Haire had a first-team All-Big Ten season, leading the conference at 1.75 made field goals per game with the second-most accurate season (87.5%) ever at Maryland. Punter Bryce McFerson was second in the league with a 44.2-yard average, earning second-team All-Big Ten honors and regularly providing a field position edge.

FINAL ANALYSIS Maryland returns 71% of its 2025 statistical production, second only to Notre Dame nationally, and it's a spot head coach Mike Locksley has long hoped to reach — an experienced squad that's a little bigger and stronger. The bad news is that last year's team wasn't very productive. While Locksley has continued to pile up impressive recruiting classes, the clock is ticking more loudly on the eighth-year head coach.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 1-8 BIG TEN)

Aug. 30	Florida Atlantic	W	39-7
Sept. 5	Northern Illinois	W	20-9
Sept. 13	Towson	W	44-17
Sept. 20	at Wisconsin	W	27-10
Oct. 4	Washington	L	20-24
Oct. 11	Nebraska	L	31-34
Oct. 18	at UCLA	L	17-20
Nov. 1	Indiana	L	10-55
Nov. 8	at Rutgers	L	20-35
Nov. 15	at Illinois	L	6-24
Nov. 22	Michigan	L	20-45
Nov. 29	at Michigan State	L	28-38

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	Hampton
Sept. 12	at UConn
Sept. 19	Virginia Tech
Sept. 26	UCLA
Oct. 3	at Nebraska
Oct. 10	at Ohio State
Oct. 17	Rutgers
Oct. 31	Illinois
Nov. 7	at Purdue
Nov. 14	Wisconsin
Nov. 21	at USC
Nov. 28	Penn State

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Zion Elee, EDGE	★★★★
2.	JaMarcus Whyce, DL	★★★★
3.	Kaden Carter, LB	★★★★
4.	Day'Jon Moore, IOL	★★★★
5.	Javonte Williams, TE	★★★★
6.	Sean Johnson, CB	★★★★
7.	Zahir Cobb, S	★★★★
8.	Darrell Carey, S	★★★★
9.	Cam Brickley II, DL	★★★★
10.	Hakim Satterwhite, CB	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Mike Locksley • Record at School: 37-49 (7+ years) • Career Record: 39-75 (9+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Clint Trickett • Defensive Coordinator: Ted Monachino • Location: College Park, Md. • Stadium: SECU Stadium (46,185)



MICHIGAN WOLVERINES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 13 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 7-2 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Michigan's 68th-ranked scoring offense gets a boost from a new face running the show and plenty of returning production. Offensive coordinator Jason Beck follows new head coach Kyle Whittingham from Utah, and Beck hopes to unlock quarterback Bryce Underwood after a disappointing freshman season. Look for the Wolverines to run more spread and to use Underwood more frequently in the run game.

Running back Jordan Marshall (932 yards, 10 TDs) returns and has some help in 5-star freshman Savion Hiter. Freshman star receiver Andrew Marsh (651 receiving yards, four TDs) elected to return, and Michigan dipped into the transfer portal to land JJ Buchanan (Utah) and Jaime Ffrench (Texas) for more passing targets.

With four starters back and more depth than last year, Michigan's offensive line is primed to make a jump as well.

DEFENSE Jay Hill from BYU takes over as defensive coordinator and wants to replicate the 2023 Michigan national title unit. That means varied looks, simulated blitzes, a mix of zone and man-coverage — all in the name of confusing opponents and forcing turnovers.

All-America defensive end John Henry Daley (11.5 sacks) follows the staff from Utah and will be an anchor up front, while Michigan is bullish on defensive tackles Trey Pierce and Enow Etta.

Linebacker is thin, but the Wolverines' secondary is seasoned and full of playmakers. Starting cornerbacks Jyaire Hill and Zeke Berry are back, along with a healthy Rod Moore at safety. Michigan added All-Big 12 defensive back Smith Snowden from Utah and Memphis safety Chris Bracy, a disruptive playmaker. If the unit can stay healthy, Michigan's defense has the ability to become a top unit in college football.

SPECIALISTS Veteran assistant Kerry Coombs takes over a special teams unit that struggled with fundamentals in 2025 and used the transfer portal to restock. Cameron Brown from UNLV is the favorite to win the punting job, while Pitt's Trey Butkowski was 20-of-23 on field-goal attempts as a freshman. Marsh made some explosive plays in the return game last year and is a front-runner to handle the job again this fall. Fello wideouts Salesi Moa and Ffrench could be in the mix there as well.

FINAL ANALYSIS The cupboard is far from bare for Whittingham, who makes the jump to Michigan after more than 30 years at Utah, the final 21 as head coach. Whittingham and his staff used the portal to help fill some holes, though concerns with depth and a difficult schedule could make for some growing pains. A 9-3 season might be the ceiling for this team.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 7-2 BIG TEN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 New Mexico W 34-17	Sept. 5 Western Michigan	1. Savion Hiter, RB ★★★★★
Sept. 6 at Oklahoma L 13-24	Sept. 12 Oklahoma	2. Carter Meadows, EDGE ★★★★★
Sept. 13 Central Michigan W 63-3	Sept. 19 UTEP	3. Salesi Moa, ATH ★★★★★
Sept. 20 at Nebraska W 30-27	Sept. 26 Iowa	4. Malakai Lee, OT ★★★★★
Oct. 4 Wisconsin W 24-10	Oct. 3 at Minnesota	5. Titan Davis, DL ★★★★★
Oct. 11 at USC L 13-31	Oct. 17 Penn State	6. Jamarion Vincent, CB ★★★★★
Oct. 18 Washington W 24-7	Oct. 24 Indiana	7. Travis Johnson, WR ★★★★★
Oct. 25 at Michigan State W 31-20	Oct. 31 at Rutgers	8. Marky Walbridge, IOL ★★★★★
Nov. 1 Purdue W 21-16	Nov. 7 Michigan State	9. Tommy Carr, QB ★★★★★
Nov. 15 at Northwestern W 24-22	Nov. 14 at Oregon	10. Jordan Deck, S ★★★★★
Nov. 22 at Maryland W 45-20	Nov. 21 UCLA	
Nov. 29 Ohio State L 9-27	Nov. 28 at Ohio State	
Dec. 31 vs. Texas # L 27-41		

#Citrus Bowl

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Kyle Whittingham • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 177-88 (21+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jason Beck • Defensive Coordinator: Jay Hill • Location: Ann Arbor, Mich. • Stadium: Michigan Stadium (107,601)



BRYCE UNDERWOOD

SCOUTING THE WOLVERINES

"I love that roster. The second that [ex-Michigan head coach] Sherrone Moore was gone, they actually got to run that roster. There are four or five players in that freshman class who'll contribute immediately, and they had a bunch of freshmen last year who contributed. On offense, you're gonna have Bryce [Underwood], Andrew Marsh and Jaime Ffrench and JJ Buchanan out of the portal. There's a lot of excitement for what that team can be this year. ... The 2027 season was the target because they really liked that 2025 class, so the thought was to build it for that third year and focus on retaining those guys while bringing in younger players. I think they can win the conference. It's not a group with a lot of household names, but there's a lot of depth with really good players."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	3	ANDREW MARSH (SO.)	9	Channing Goodwin (Jr.)
WR	13	JJ Buchanan* (So.)	81	Jamar Browder (So.)
WR	10	Jaime Ffrench* (So.)	12	Salesi Moa (Fr.)
LT	77	BLAKE FRAZIER (JR.)	65	Andrew Babalola (So.)
LG	71	EVAN LINK (SR.)	74	Avery Gach (So.)
C	53	JAKE GUARNERA (JR.)	67	Houston Ka'aha'a-Torres* (So.)
RG	55	Nathan Efobi (Sr.)	50	Luke Hamilton (Jr.)
RT	54	ANDREW SPRAGUE (JR.)	70	Brady Norton (Sr.)
TE	83	Zack Marshall (Sr.)	80	Hogan Hansen (Jr.)
QB	19	BRYCE UNDERWOOD (SO.)		Brayden Fowler-Nicolosi* (Sr.)
RB	23	Jordan Marshall (Jr.)	5	Savion Hiter (Fr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	90	John Henry Daley* (Sr.)	94	Nate Marshall (So.)
DT	17	Enow Etta (Sr.)	91	Jonah Lea'ea (Sr.)
DT	95	TREY PIERCE (SR.)	54	Deyvid Palepale (Jr.)
DE	9	Cameron Brandt (Sr.)	8	Dominic Nichols (Jr.)
ILB	18	Troy Bowles (Sr.)	12	Nathaniel Owusu-Boateng (So.)
ILB	29	Chase Taylor (So.)	13	Aisea Moa* (Sr.)
CB	0	JYAIRE HILL (SR.)	2	Shamari Earls (So.)
CB	10	ZEKE BERRY (SR.)	16	Jo'Ziah Edmond (Jr.)
NB	3	Smith Snowden* (Sr.)	20	Chris Bracy* (Jr.)
S	1	Rod Moore (Sr.)	25	Mason Curtis (Jr.)
S	20	Chris Bracy* (Jr.)	6	Jordan Young (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Trey Butkowski* (So.)	KR	3	Andrew Marsh (So.)
P		Cameron Brown* (So.)	PR	3	Andrew Marsh (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

DYLAN WIDGER-IMAGN IMAGES



JORDAN HALL

SCOUTING THE SPARTANS

"Their entire staff of position coaches made me go, 'Oh, s—. Interesting.' They brought in a lot of good coaches, so I think they'll be a good team this year. I don't think they added a lot of players that change the game for them, but you could tell from the outside that the culture wasn't great. Maybe them losing a bunch of players and talent and completely hitting the reset button is actually a good thing. I'm pretty bullish on them. ... I thought picking up [offensive line coach] Nick Tabacca was really smart. And [safeties coach] James Adams, he is absolutely unbelievable. He's the best I've ever been around in terms of a coach, an evaluator, a recruiter; he makes his guys want to run through a brick wall every day. Any staff that he's on, stock up big time."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	6	Fredrick Moore* (Jr.)	5	Samson Gash (Fr.)
WR	8	KK Smith* (Jr.)	22	Jack Yanachik (Jr.)
WR	13	Chrishon McCray (Sr.)	16	Zach Washington (Fr.)
LT	75	Ben Murawski* (Sr.)	71	Robert Wright Jr.* (Jr.)
LG	52	Nick Sharpe* (Sr.)	70	Luka Vincic (Sr.)
C	63	Trent Fraley* (Sr.)	50	Antonio Johnson (Fr.)
RG	55	Rakeem Johnson (So.)	77	Andrew Dennis (So.)
RT	58	CONNER MOORE (SR.)	73	Rustin Young (So.)
TE	12	Carson Gulker* (Sr.)	82	Brennan Parachek (Jr.)
QB	11	Alessio Milivojevic (So.)	2	Cam Fancher* (Sr.)
RB	0	Cam Edwards* (Sr.)	7	Brandon Tullis (Jr.)

DEFENSE (0)

EDGE	23	Kenny Soares Jr.* (Sr.)	11	Anelu Lafaele (So.)
DT	55	Ben Roberts (Sr.)	98	Derrick Simmons (Fr.)
DT	96	Eli Coenen* (Jr.)	52	Mikeshun Beeler (So.)
DL	51	Kekai Burnett (So.)	25	Carlos Hazelwood (So.)
WLB	44	Caleb Wheatland* (Sr.)	18	Dion Crawford* (Sr.)
MLB	5	Jordan Hall (Sr.)	45	Brady Pretzlaff (So.)
CB	19	Charles Brantley* (Sr.)	22	Tyran Chappell* (So.)
CB	3	Tre Bell* (Sr.)	0	Nihay Burt (Sr.)
NB	7	Michael Richard* (Sr.)	34	Khalil Majeed (Sr.)
S	21	Nikai Martinez (Sr.)	2	Devin Vaught* (Jr.)
S	30	Aveon Grose (Sr.)	31	Deuce Edwards (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	37	Liam Boyd* (Sr.)	KR	32	Kenneth Williams* (Jr.)
P	9	Rhys Dakin* (Jr.)	PR	5	Samson Gash (Fr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MICHIGAN STATE SPARTANS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 72 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 17 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 1-8 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Starting quarterback Alessio Milivojevic continues to run with the opportunity after throwing for 986 yards across four starts in 2025. Twenty-five sacks in those games show he'll need a quicker trigger and help from his offensive line, built from portal additions like tackle Ben Murawski (UConn) and center Trent Fraley (North Dakota State). In the backfield, UConn transfer Cam Edwards' 1,240 yards from scrimmage ranked 13th in the FBS last year, but that came against a weaker schedule.

Offensive coordinator Nick Sheridan's calling card is putting playmakers in position to perform. Tight end-quarterback-receiver-magician Carson Gulker, a transfer from Div. II national champion Ferris State, should give him lots of options, as should receiver Chrishon McCray. This group will float around average, but it'll make you say "wow" a few times each game.

DEFENSE When coordinator Joe Rossi put together his staff, he focused on energizers. This defense will run into some personnel problems, but the Spartans hope they can develop inferior talent beyond expectations.

Senior Jordan Hall is the Mike linebacker, and he gets some help with productive transfers Caleb Wheatland (Auburn) and Dion Crawford (Buffalo). Nikai Martinez returns at safety with old teammate Charles Brantley, who spent last season at Miami (Fla.), coming back at corner.

Michigan State took the ball away from its opponents only nine times last season, the sixth-lowest total in the FBS. That had more to do with a defensive front that couldn't generate pressure than it did a secondary lacking true playmakers. The defensive line room is thin again, which will cause problems.

SPECIALISTS Coordinator LeVar Woods made Iowa special teams famous, and now he leaves Kirk Ferentz's staff to do the same at Michigan State. The devil is in the details, he says, and his players learned well. It took him four pages of notes to install plays for Aussie punter Rhys Dakin, who follows his coach from Iowa and fills the shoes of NFL-bound Ryan Eckley. Transfer placekicker Liam Boyd missed more short kicks (4-for-6) than long (3-for-4) at Charlotte, but Michigan State's offense may need him kicking from long range anyway. In the return game, a lot of speedy wideouts will compete for reps.

FINAL ANALYSIS A lot of players need to get a lot better, quickly, for Michigan State to win more than four or five games this season. But that's expected for new head coach Pat Fitzgerald and Co. in what amounts to a rebuilding year. Success will be measured by how this season prepares the team for the next, which is probably the last thing the Spartan faithful want to hear. That's the price of changing coaches twice in three seasons.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 1-8 BIG TEN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	Western Michigan	W	23-6	Sept. 5	Toledo	1. Collin Campbell, OT	★★★★
Sept. 6	Boston College (ot)	W	42-40	Sept. 12	Eastern Michigan	2. Eli Bickel, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 13	Youngstown State	W	41-24	Sept. 19	at Notre Dame	3. Samson Gash, WR	★★★★
Sept. 20	at USC	L	31-45	Sept. 26	Nebraska	4. Kayd Coffman, QB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Nebraska	L	27-38	Oct. 3	at Wisconsin	5. Joe Caudill, TE	★★★★
Oct. 11	UCLA	L	13-38	Oct. 10	Illinois	6. Zach Washington, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	at Indiana	L	13-38	Oct. 17	Northwestern	7. Brayden Thomas, S	★★★
Oct. 25	Michigan	L	20-31	Oct. 24	at UCLA	8. Adam Shaw, LB	★★★
Nov. 1	at Minnesota (ot)	L	20-23	Nov. 7	at Michigan	9. Eddie Whiting, TE	★★★
Nov. 15	Penn State	L	10-28	Nov. 14	Washington	10. Tristan Comer, OT	★★★
Nov. 22	at Iowa	L	17-20	Nov. 21	Oregon		
Nov. 29	Maryland	W	38-28	Nov. 28	at Rutgers		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Pat Fitzgerald • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 110-101 (17 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Nick Sheridan • Defensive Coordinators: Joe Rossi, Max Bullough • Location: East Lansing, Mich. • Stadium: Spartan Stadium (75,005)



MINNESOTA GOLDEN GOPHERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 42 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 11 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 5-4 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Head coach P.J. Fleck turned heads at Big Ten Media Days last year when he shared his goal of a College Football Playoff bid in 2025 despite an inexperienced quarterback. That didn't happen, but QB Drake Lindsey built a foundation. His play — 63% completion rate, 2,382 passing yards, 18 touchdowns and only six interceptions — inspired hope for a potential jump in his redshirt sophomore season.

Minnesota retained its Nos. 2-4 pass-catchers and added three wide-outs via the portal, with Cincinnati's Noah Jennings topping the list.

To help Lindsey out, Minnesota must improve in the run game. The Gophers ranked 116th in the nation at 3.57 yards per carry. Poor offensive line play was a key factor, and Minnesota is banking on improvements from returning starters and contributors.

Senior running back Darius Taylor has worked with a chef and taken Pilates classes to be at his best. He led Minnesota with 915 yards from scrimmage (670 rushing, 245 receiving) last season. If he reaches 1,500 this fall, it will certainly enhance Minnesota's postseason prospects.

DEFENSE The Gophers have the seventh-highest percentage of returning production for 2026 according to ESPN, with 71% of their offense and 65% of their defense coming back.

The key defection, however, was rising junior safety/returner/receiver Koi Perich, who transferred to Oregon. While Perich had a sophomore slump in 2025, his departure might lower Minnesota's ceiling.

The Gophers retained redshirt junior safety Kerry Brown, who was more reliable than Perich a year ago, and have other playmakers, notably linebacker Maverick Baranowski (tied for sixth in Big Ten with 103 tackles) and defensive end Anthony Smith (Big Ten-best 12.5 sacks). The biggest addition via the portal is TJ Bush Jr. from Cal; the senior end has amassed 91 pressures and 13 sacks across three years.

Minnesota lost its top four defensive tackles from last year, meaning 310-pound Marshall transfer Naquan Crowder needs to be an anchor.

SPECIALISTS Field-goal kicking was a struggle last season, leading to a competition between Beckham Sunderland, a Michigan transfer, and Daniel Jackson. But neither has attempted a collegiate field goal. Punter Tom Weston had a quality first season, but with Perich's exit, the Gophers will need to find primary returners for both punts and kickoffs.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Gophers are in the bottom half of the Big Ten in paying players but have consistently finished in the top half of the league. That should continue this fall, especially if Lindsey can make a leap.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 5-4 BIG TEN)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	Buffalo	W 23-10	Sept. 3	Eastern Illinois	1. Aaden Aytch, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 6	Northwestern State	W 66-0	Sept. 12	Mississippi State	2. Quayd Hendryx, WR	★★★★
Sept. 13	at Cal	L 14-27	Sept. 19	Akron	3. Howie Johnson, DL	★★★★
Sept. 27	Rutgers	W 31-28	Sept. 26	at Washington	4. Ryan Estrada, RB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Ohio State	L 3-42	Oct. 3	Michigan	5. Roman Voss, TE	★★★
Oct. 11	Purdue	W 27-20	Oct. 10	at Purdue	6. Andrew Trout, OT	★★★
Oct. 17	Nebraska	W 24-6	Oct. 24	Iowa	7. Hudson Dunn, LB	★★★
Oct. 25	at Iowa	L 3-41	Oct. 31	at Indiana	8. Gavin Meier, IOL	★★★
Nov. 1	Michigan State (ot)	W 23-20	Nov. 7	UCLA	9. Rico Blassingame, WR	★★★
Nov. 14	at Oregon	L 13-42	Nov. 14	at Penn State	10. Lamont Hamilton, CB	★★★
Nov. 22	at Northwestern	L 35-38	Nov. 21	Northwestern		
Nov. 29	Wisconsin	W 17-7	Nov. 28	at Wisconsin		
Dec. 26	vs. New Mexico # (ot) W	20-17				*Per Rivals

#Rate Bowl

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: P.J. Fleck • Record at School: 66-44 (9 years) • Career Record: 96-66 (13 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Greg Harbaugh Jr. • Defensive Coordinator: Danny Collins • Location: Minneapolis, Minn. • Stadium: Huntington Bank Stadium (50,805)



DRAKE LINDSEY

SCOUTING THE GOPHERS

"They're so consistent. I would anticipate them staying at the level they've been at, probably not competing for the conference. I wouldn't call them a dark horse. They won't be in the bottom half [of the Big Ten]. ... They evaluate really well. They're just like Illinois. Their GM [Gerrit Chernoff] is awesome. They have a really, really good personnel staff. They know exactly what their wheelhouse is, and they strike really well in it. It's funny because P.J. Fleck's thing is 'Row the Boat,' which is so fitting for them because in college football, whether the decision is right or wrong, as long as everybody is in it together, you're usually gonna do something good. That's what they are."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	8	JALEN SMITH (SO.)	3	Perry Thompson* (Jr.)
WR	11	Javon Tracy (Sr.)	7	Bradley Martino (Fr.)
WR	13	Noah Jennings* (Sr.)	84	Hayden Moore (Fr.)
LT	50	NATHAN ROY (SO.)	60	Kaveon Lee (Fr.)
LG	59	Tony Nelson (Sr.)	77	Nick Spence (Fr.)
C	78	ASHTON BEERS (SR.)	56	Brett Carroll (So.)
RG	65	GREG JOHNSON (SR.)	58	Jaden Ball (So.)
RT	51	Daniel Shipp (Fr.)	68	Bennett Warren* (So.)
TE	19	Pierce Walsh (Jr.)	88	Jacob Simpson (So.)
QB	5	DRAKE LINDSEY (SO.)	6	Max Shikenjanski (Jr.)
RB	1	DARIUS TAYLOR (SR.)	2	A.J. Turner (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	0	ANTHONY SMITH (SR.)	11	Karter Menz (Jr.)
DT	70	Naquan Crowder* (Jr.)	55	Jaylin Hicks (So.)
DT	93	Riley Sunram (So.)	90	Xion Chapman (Jr.)
DE	13	TJ Bush Jr.* (Sr.)	1	JAXON HOWARD (JR.)
LB	6	MAVERICK BARANOWSKI (SR.)	46	Mason Carrier (So.)
LB	49	Matt Kingsbury (Jr.)	2	Emmanuel Karmo (So.)
CB	17	JOHN NESTOR (SR.)	21	Naiim Parrish (So.)
CB	5	Aydan West* (So.)	8	Mike Gerald (So.)
NB	9	Garrison Monroe (Jr.)	13	Zahir Rainer (So.)
S	14	KERRY BROWN (JR.)	4	Zack Harden (So.)
S	7	Aidan Gousby (Sr.)	22	Mekhai Smith* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	92	Beckham Sunderland* (Sr.)	KR	13	Noah Jennings* (Sr.)
P	42	Tom Weston (Jr.)	PR	11	Javon Tracy (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NYZIAH HUNTER

SCOUTING THE CORNHUSKERS

"They're in a ton of denial with the quarterback situation. Dylan Raiola is as good as they get as a player and as a person; losing him, I thought he was their last hope. He was the pin that was holding that thing together. I don't imagine they're gonna do anything special. I think five wins, maybe six wins at the most [this] year. If they hit seven, I'd be shocked. ... [Head coach] Matt Rhule has some great aspects. He can make you run through a wall, but there's just always so much turnover with his staff. I know that it's a tough environment for those coaches to be in. Rhule makes it like that on purpose because he doesn't want you to get comfortable. I don't want to say his model isn't going to work, but I don't know."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	13	NYZIAH HUNTER (JR.)	18	Quinn Clark (So.)
WR	11	Kwazi Gilmer* (Jr.)	19	Cortez Mills Jr. (So.)
WR	2	JACORY BARNEY JR. (JR.)	17	Larry Miles (Fr.)
LT	57	ELIJAH PRITCHETT (SR.)	71	Claude Mpouma (Fr.)
LG	65	Paul Mubenga* (Jr.)	62	Sam Sledge (Jr.)
C	51	JUSTIN EVANS (SR.)	58	Jake Peters (So.)
RG	54	Brendan Black* (Sr.)	75	Tyler Knaak (Sr.)
RT	55	Tree Babalade* (Jr.)	77	GUNNAR GOTTULA (JR.)
TE	44	LUKE LINDENMEYER (SR.)	4	Janiran Bonner (Jr.)
QB	10	Anthony Colandrea* (Sr.)	14	TJ Lateef (So.)
RB	35	Mekhi Nelson (So.)	22	Isaiah Mozee (So.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	15	Anthony Jones Jr.* (Sr.)	96	WILLIAMS NWANERI (SO.)
DT	5	Riley Van Poppel (Jr.)	92	Sua Lefotu (Jr.)
DT	44	Jahsear Whittington* (So.)	34	Owen Stoudmire* (Sr.)
DE	11	CAMERON LENHARDT (SO.)	93	Kade Pietrzak (So.)
LB	9	VINCENT SHAVERS JR. (JR.)	24	Dexter Foster* (Jr.)
LB	33	Owen Chambliss* (Jr.)	40	Dawson Merritt (So.)
CB	10	ANDREW MARSHALL (SR.)	22	Victor Evans III* (Sr.)
CB	25	Jeremiah Charles (Jr.)	16	Danny Odem III (Fr.)
S	26	Dwayne McDougale III (Sr.)	23	Caleb Benning (So.)
S	13	Jamir Conn (Sr.)	21	REX GUTHRIE (SO.)
S	37	DONOVAN JONES (SO.)	31	Mario Buford (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	91	Kyle Cunanan (Jr.)	KR	2	Jacory Barney Jr. (Jr.)
P	83	Archie Wilson (So.)	PR	2	Jacory Barney Jr. (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NEBRASKA CORNHUSKERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 38 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-5 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Nebraska's offense goes in a new direction in 2026 with quarterback Anthony Colandrea, the reigning Mountain West Offensive Player of the Year, transferring in from UNLV. Colandrea's mobility and ability to extend plays could bring more explosiveness and create big-play opportunities for a veteran wide receiver group that returns starters NyZIAH Hunter (43 catches, 617 yards, five TDs) and Jacory Barney Jr. (45 catches, 484 yards, five TDs) and adds productive transfer Kwazi Gilmer from UCLA. Sophomore wideout Quinn Clark has breakout potential as well.

The Huskers eschewed a transfer portal back to replace All-American Emmett Johnson and will turn to returners Mekhi Nelson and Isaiah Mozee, who both saw time, albeit sparingly, behind Johnson. Freshman Jamal Rule is another name to watch in 2026.

Up front, Nebraska added veteran guards Paul Mubenga and Brendan Black from LSU and Iowa State, respectively, as well as tackle Tree Babalade from South Carolina, all of whom bring size and experience. Veteran starting center Justin Evans and left tackle Elijah Pritchett return, giving the team a bigger, more agile line in 2026.

DEFENSE Defensive coordinator Rob Aurich arrives from San Diego State, hoping for the same quick turnaround that he engineered with the Aztecs. Nebraska will run an attacking 4-2-5 scheme and seek balance after finishing No. 3 against the pass in 2025 but No. 98 against the run. Aurich's 2025 group at SDSU finished 12th in the country in total defense.

Improvement along the defensive line, where veterans Riley Van Poppel, Williams Nwaneri and Cameron Lenhardt return, is paramount. Transfer portal additions Jahsear Whittington and Anthony Jones Jr. will be expected to add instant pass rush for a defense that averaged fewer than two sacks per game on the year. The linebacker corps should be improved with returning starter Vincent Shavers Jr. and the additions of San Diego State's Owen Chambliss and Oregon State's Dexter Foster.

SPECIALISTS Last year, the Huskers engineered a big turnaround on special teams under coordinator Mike Ekeler, who moved on to USC in the offseason. Former NFL and Nebraska kicker Brett Maher takes over the group, which returns placekicker Kyle Cunanan (16-of-19 on field goals in 2025) and ambipedal punter Archie Wilson.

FINAL ANALYSIS Back-to-back bowl games represented progress, but in Year 4 of the Matt Rhule era, new pieces and schemes will need to click quickly for Nebraska to show additional growth in 2026 against a difficult Big Ten schedule that features Indiana, Ohio State and Oregon.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-5 BIG TEN)

Aug. 28	vs. Cincinnati #	W	20-17
Sept. 6	Akron	W	68-0
Sept. 13	Houston Christian	W	59-7
Sept. 20	Michigan	L	27-30
Oct. 4	Michigan State	W	38-27
Oct. 11	at Maryland	W	34-31
Oct. 17	at Minnesota	L	6-24
Oct. 25	Northwestern	W	28-21
Nov. 1	USC	L	17-21
Nov. 8	at UCLA	W	28-21
Nov. 22	at Penn State	L	10-37
Nov. 28	Iowa	L	16-40
Dec. 31	vs. Utah %	L	22-44

#Kansas City, MO %Las Vegas Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	Ohio
Sept. 12	Bowling Green
Sept. 19	North Dakota
Sept. 26	at Michigan State
Oct. 3	Maryland
Oct. 10	Indiana
Oct. 17	at Oregon
Oct. 31	Washington
Nov. 7	at Illinois
Nov. 14	at Rutgers
Nov. 21	Ohio State
Nov. 27	at Iowa

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Danny Odem III, CB	★★★★
2. Claude Mpouma, OT	★★★★
3. Jamal Rule, RB	★★★
4. Luke Sorensen, TE	★★★
5. Larry Miles, WR	★★★
6. Nalin Scott, WR	★★★
7. Rex Waterman, IOL	★★★
8. Dylan Berymon, DL	★★★
9. Hayden Ainsworth, IOL	★★★
10. Jase Reynolds, LB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Matt Rhule • Record at School: 19-19 (3 years) • Career Record: 66-62 (10 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Dana Holgorsen • Defensive Coordinator: Rob Aurich • Location: Lincoln, Neb. • Stadium: Memorial Stadium (85,458)



NORTHWESTERN WILDCATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 57 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 14 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-5 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Northwestern has never made a hire quite like new offensive coordinator Chip Kelly. The 62-year-old's task is upgrading an offense that has flatlined for some time — 129th nationally in scoring (21.3 ppg) since 2014. “You don’t feel like there are any wasted plays,” head coach David Braun says of Kelly’s system. “The ability to change the tempo at which you’re playing, but still operate within the offense, is seamless.”

Kelly recruited Aidan Chiles while coaching UCLA and will work with the Michigan State transfer quarterback, who showed promise early in his career but was benched late last season.

Northwestern didn’t take any transfer wide receivers and will lean on Griffin Wilde, a third-team All-Big Ten selection in 2025, and emerging Haydon Eligon II. The team is bullish about tight end transfers Alex Honig (6-foot-6, 275) and Luke Dehnicke, but Braun notes, “The mid-tier of that wide receiver room is going to have to elevate.”

Running back projects well with Caleb Komolafe, Joseph Himon II, short-yardage ace Robby Preckel and several transfers. The offensive line improved in 2025 but must replace multiple NFL departures. Oklahoma State tackle Grant Seagren is the biggest addition, and he joins standout interior lineman Ezomo Oratokhai.

DEFENSE Northwestern should have one of the Big Ten’s best secondaries, headlined by all-league safety Robert Fitzgerald, cornerback Josh Fussell and nickel Braden Turner. A healthy Damon Walters at field safety is key, but Braun likes the depth and talent.

Linebacker and defensive end should be solid, especially if transfers Kobie McKinzie (Oklahoma) and Jamaal Johnson (UCF) complement holdovers Braydon Brus and Michael Kilbane, who had 7.5 tackles for a loss and 3.5 sacks in 2025. Northwestern has questions at defensive tackle around senior Brendan Flakes.

SPECIALISTS Northwestern added Bowling Green transfer placekicker Jackson Kleather. Decorated recruit Nikola Dugandzic should take over punting in his second season, while Himon and wide receivers Drew Wagner and Chase Farrell should handle returns. Assistant coach Paul Creighton will focus solely on special teams this season.

FINAL ANALYSIS Kelly’s arrival and the October opening of the \$862 million brand-new Ryan Field fuel excitement. Northwestern is investing in football, and Braun wants to become a College Football Playoff contender. His plan might take time, though, as Northwestern visits Indiana, Oregon and Ohio State and hosts Penn State and Iowa. A third bowl appearance in four seasons is a reasonable goal.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-5 BIG TEN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at Tulane L 3-23	Sept. 5 South Dakota State	1. Jaden McDuffie, WR ★★★★★
Sept. 5 Western Illinois W 42-7	Sept. 19 Colorado	2. Owen Fors, IOL ★★★★★
Sept. 13 Oregon L 14-34	Sept. 26 at Indiana	3. Jack Fuchs, OT ★★★
Sept. 27 UCLA W 17-14	Oct. 3 Penn State	4. Leighton Burbach, OT ★★★
Oct. 4 ULM W 42-7	Oct. 10 Ball State	5. Nick Zalewski, EDGE ★★★
Oct. 11 at Penn State W 22-21	Oct. 17 at Michigan State	6. Tre Hoskins, DL ★★★
Oct. 18 Purdue W 19-0	Oct. 24 Rutgers	7. Sean Morris II, RB ★★★
Oct. 25 at Nebraska L 21-28	Oct. 31 at Oregon	8. Jacob Miller, OT ★★★
Nov. 7 at USC L 17-38	Nov. 7 Iowa	9. Gabe Davis-Ray, S ★★★
Nov. 15 Michigan L 22-24	Nov. 14 at Ohio State	10. Tom McGlinchey, TE ★★★
Nov. 22 Minnesota W 38-35	Nov. 21 at Minnesota	
Nov. 29 at Illinois L 13-20	Nov. 28 Illinois	
Dec. 26 vs. Central Michigan #W 34-7		
#GameAbove Sports Bowl		
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: David Braun • Record at School: 19-19 (3 years)		
Career Record: 19-19 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Chip Kelly		
Defensive Coordinator: Tim McGarigle • Location: Evanston, Ill.		
Stadium: Ryan Field (35,000)		



GRIFFIN WILDE

SCOUTING THE WILDCATS

“I was super interested in the [new Northwestern offensive coordinator] Chip Kelly move. Just from a personnel-meeting-scheme standpoint, I just imagine their personnel department was like, ‘What the f— do we do now?’ Everything they’ve built with that team is like this ground-and-pound, man-zone running scheme that you have some play-action of it. I thought they had a couple of good young players. I don’t think they evaluate like Minnesota or Illinois, but I wouldn’t say they’re poor at it. ... Kelly is run-heavy, and there’s this misconception that he’s been someone who throws it all over the yard. He’s not, he’s just a tempo guy, and that’s not their game at all. I don’t think it was a shocking move, but I think it raised some eyebrows.”

—An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	17	GRIFFIN WILDE (SR.)	10	Ricky Ahumaraeze (Jr.)
WR	80	HAYDEN ELIGON II (JR.)	14	Dube Enongene (Fr.)
WR	19	Drew Wagner (Jr.)	20	Chase Farrell (So.)
LT	74	Grant Seagren* (Jr.)	71	Dennis Rahouski (So.)
LG	73	Deuce McGuire (Sr.)	78	Trey Boyd (Fr.)
C	62	EZOMO ORATOKHAI (SO.)	77	Idrys Cotton (So.)
RG	77	Idrys Cotton (So.)	64	Anthony Birsá (Jr.)
RT	75	Arkel Anugwom* (Jr.)	61	David Anchondo* (Jr.)
TE	86	Alex Honig* (Sr.)	84	Luke Dehnicke* (So.)
QB	0	Aidan Chiles* (Sr.)	2	Ryan Boe (So.)
RB	5	CALEB KOMOLAFE (JR.)	6	Joseph Himon II (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	47	Michael Kilbane (Sr.)	5	Dominic Kirks* (So.)
DT	15	BRENDAN FLAKES (SR.)	54	Tyler Gant (Jr.)
DT	95	Mason Mayne (Fr.)	88	Migo Jackson (Sr.)
DE	24	Jamaal Johnson* (Sr.)	44	Callen Campbell (So.)
LB	2	Kobie McKinzie* (Sr.)	34	Payton Roth (Jr.)
LB	33	BRAYDON BRUS (SR.)	42	Nigel Glover (Jr.)
CB	13	JOSH FUSSELL (JR.)	4	Montae Pate* (Sr.)
CB	7	Ore Adeyi (Sr.)	25	Marquet Dorsey Jr. (So.)
NB	9	BRADEN TURNER (SR.)	3	Brenden Deasfernandes* (Sr.)
S	6	ROBERT FITZGERALD (SR.)	0	Alijah Jones (So.)
S	21	Damon Walters (Jr.)	29	Jon Jon Stevens Jr. (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	90	Jackson Kleather* (Sr.)	KR	6	Joseph Himon II (Sr.)
P	92	Nikola Dugandzic (Fr.)	PR	19	Drew Wagner (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

DAVID BANKS-IMAGN IMAGES



JEREMIAH SMITH

SCOUTING THE BUCKEYES

"I thought the [defensive coordinator] Matt Patricia hire was awesome last year. What made them so good was they were super simple. They'd let you take something super short and run your base stuff, and then not budge to that. Then the second you get out of your stuff, they're ready for it. They were mentally tougher than you. ... It was so innovative what they did with their coordinators because in today's game, coordinators are being taken out of their college stuff. They thought, why not bring in two NFL guys [as coordinators] who might not — from the outside looking in — be known for their relatability to players and all that other BS who are just known for being schematic dudes that know what the f— they're doing from a scheme standpoint, and they've executed that really well."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (8)

WR	4	JEREMIAH SMITH (JR.)	7	Phillip Bell (Fr.)
WR	15	Chris Henry Jr. (Fr.)	5	Kyle Parker* (Jr.)
WR	1	BRANDON INNIS (SR.)	3	Devin McCuin* (Sr.)
LT	67	AUSTIN SIERVELD (JR.)	77	Sam Greer (Fr.)
LG	51	LUKE MONTGOMERY (SR.)	76	Jake Cook (Fr.)
C	75	CARSON HINZMAN (SR.)	62	Joshua Padilla (Jr.)
RG	70	PHILLIP DANIELS (JR.)	58	Gabe VanSickle (So.)
RT	69	Ian Moore (So.)	74	Carter Lowe (Fr.)
TE	83	Nate Roberts (So.)	84	Hunter Welcing* (Sr.)
QB	10	JULIAN SAYIN (SO.)	9	Tavien St. Clair (Fr.)
RB	25	BO JACKSON (SO.)	32	Isaiah West (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	2	KENYATTA JACKSON JR. (SR.)	12	Beau Atkinson (Sr.)
DT	96	Eddrick Houston (Jr.)	94	Jason Moore (Jr.)
DT	3	James Smith* (Sr.)	55	John Walker* (Jr.)
DE	9	Zion Grady (So.)	4	Qua Russaw* (Jr.)
MLB	26	Payton Pierce (Jr.)	20	Cincere Johnson (Fr.)
WLB	14	Christian Alliegro* (Sr.)	5	Riley Pettijohn (So.)
CB	7	JERMAINE MATTHEWS JR. (SR.)	24	Dominick Kelly* (So.)
CB	6	Devin Sanchez (So.)	18	Cam Calhoun* (Jr.)
NB	1	Earl Little Jr.* (Sr.)	13	Miles Lockhart (So.)
SS	8	JAYLEN MCCLAIN (JR.)	16	Blaine Bradford (Fr.)
FS	11	Terry Moore* (Sr.)	10	Leroy Roker III (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	96	Connor Hawkins* (So.)	KR	2	Legend Bey (Fr.)
P	42	Joe McGuire (Jr.)	PR	1	Brandon Inniss (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



OHIO STATE BUCKEYES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 1 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 12-2, 9-0 BIG TEN

OFFENSE If Julian Sayin can remain efficient and further develop his game — perhaps with more bursts from the pocket — there's no reason why he can't be a Heisman Trophy contender once again. He looks to build on 3,610-yard, 32-touchdown season in which he completed an eye-popping 77% of his pass attempts.

Sayin still has plenty of firepower at his disposal, headlined, of course, by the beastly Jeremiah Smith and also featuring veteran Brandon Inniss and newcomer Chris Henry Jr.

Sayin also will have the benefit of a power-running game, which is a trademark of new offensive coordinator Arthur Smith. Running backs Bo Jackson and Isaiah West were borderline sensational last year and figure to help balance the attack while maneuvering behind an experienced offensive line. Four starters return up front, a group led by centerpiece Carson Hinzman and left tackle Austin Siereveld.

DEFENSE After guiding the nation's top stop unit last year, coordinator Matt Patricia has major holes to fill, including the loss of Arvell Reese, Sonny Styles and Caleb Downs, all top-seven overall NFL Draft picks. Still, there are athletes aplenty, and assistants Larry Johnson, James Laurinaitis and Tim Walton are all elite at developing their position groups.

The D-line will feature end Kenyatta Jackson Jr. and Alabama transfer James Smith, one of several large interior defenders with surprising lateral quickness and an ability to stuff the run. The linebacking corps will need to learn on the fly but already is showing promise.

In the secondary, Jermaine Matthews Jr. is welcoming his new role as the Buckeyes' top corner, while Duke transfer Terry Moore should emerge as a focal point at free safety.

SPECIALISTS Ill-timed missed kicks, lackluster punt returns and inconsistent kick coverage have haunted OSU over the years. Baylor transfer Connor Hawkins will try to steady the ship at placekicker. Meanwhile, Joe McGuire is back after averaging a middling 42.4 yards per punt last season. Inniss should feature as a top return option.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Ryan Day is a proven survivor who has adapted well enough to scale the summit of modern college football. His new CEO-type approach should be empowering to Arthur Smith and Patricia, both former NFL head coaches. This staff will have to hustle to fine-tune a roster littered with a program-record 51 newcomers and a loaded schedule, but if the defense is able to reload, all championship possibilities are on the table.

2025 RESULTS (12-2, 9-0 BIG TEN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Texas W 14-7	Sept. 5 Ball State	1. Jay Timmons, CB ★★★★★
Sept. 6 Grambling W 70-0	Sept. 12 at Texas	2. Jerquaden Guilford, WR ★★★★★
Sept. 13 Ohio W 37-9	Sept. 19 Kent State	3. Khary Wilder, EDGE ★★★★★
Sept. 27 at Washington W 24-6	Sept. 26 Illinois	4. Cincere Johnson, LB ★★★★★
Oct. 4 Minnesota W 42-3	Oct. 3 at Iowa	5. Chris Henry Jr., WR ★★★★★
Oct. 11 at Illinois W 34-16	Oct. 10 Maryland	6. Blaine Bradford, S ★★★★★
Oct. 18 at Wisconsin W 34-0	Oct. 17 at Indiana	7. Sam Greer, OT ★★★★★
Nov. 1 Penn State W 38-14	Oct. 31 at USC	8. Jordan Thomas, CB ★★★★★
Nov. 8 at Purdue W 34-10	Nov. 7 Oregon	9. Braxton Rembert, LB ★★★★★
Nov. 15 UCLA W 48-10	Nov. 14 Northwestern	10. Damari Simeon, DL ★★★★★
Nov. 22 Rutgers W 42-9	Nov. 21 at Nebraska	
Nov. 29 at Michigan W 27-9	Nov. 28 Michigan	
Dec. 6 vs. Indiana # L 10-13		
Dec. 31 vs. Miami (Fla.) % L 14-24		
#Indianapolis %Cotton Bowl: CFB Playoff Quarterfinal		
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Ryan Day • Record at School: 82-12 (7+ years)		
Career Record: 82-12 (7+ years) • Offensive Coordinators: Arthur Smith, Keenan Bailey • Defensive Coordinator: Matt Patricia		
Location: Columbus, Ohio • Stadium: Ohio Stadium (102,780)		

*Per Rivals

OFFENSE The story of the offseason for Oregon was how many draftable Ducks opted to return in 2026, headlined by quarterback Dante Moore. The “thunder and lightning” duo of Jordon Davison and Dierre Hill Jr. combined for 1,323 rushing yards as freshman backups, and now they’re the feature backs.

Receivers Dakorien Moore and Jeremiah McClellan are also stepping into bigger roles as sophomores; the X-factors there will be incoming UAB transfer Iverson Hooks and returner Evan Stewart, who has much to prove after a season lost to a knee injury. Kenyon Sadiq is gone at tight end, but there will be minimal drop-off to Jamari Johnson.

The Ducks hope the same can be said about the new-look line, led by another returner who spurned the NFL Draft — center Iapani Laloulu.

DEFENSE The entire starting defensive front is back after also opting to skip the 2026 draft and await 2027. With Bear Alexander and A’Mauri Washington plugging up the middle, and Matayo Uiagalelei and Teitum Tuioti manning the ends, this could be the best four-man front in the country. The Ducks added depth through the portal but also hope their own development of Aydin Breland, Matthew Johnson and Nasir Wyatt will pay dividends there.

Jerry Mixon leads the inside linebackers after a breakout 2025 season, and Devon Jackson brings elite athleticism to the position. Brandon Finney Jr. is one of the best young corners in the country, if not one of the best corners, period. The portal did bring help on the back end, in safety Koi Perich (Minnesota) and nickel Carl Williams IV (Baylor). Perich looks like a more than capable replacement for the departed Dillon Thieneman. Watch for a potential breakout season from corner Na’eem Offord.

SPECIALISTS The kicking game will be a question mark until proven otherwise, after the Ducks graduated their kicker and punter. When the placekicking unit takes the field, it’s possible all three guys who touch the ball will be portal additions — long-snapper RJ Todd, punter/holder Bailey Ettridge and placekicker Keaton Emmett, who will look to beat out returners Gage Hurych and Rocco Graziano.

FINAL ANALYSIS Under head coach Dan Lanning, Oregon football is now recruiting and competing like one of the top five or 10 programs in the nation. There’s one last hurdle to clear: bringing home the school’s first national championship. With new coordinators on both sides of the ball, it’s conceivable that there could be some early growing pains this fall. But with all the talent returning, the goal is crystal clear.

2025 RESULTS (13-2, 8-1 BIG TEN)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Montana State	W 59-13	Sept. 5	Boise State	1. Jalen Lott, WR	★★★★★
Sept. 6	Oklahoma State	W 69-3	Sept. 12	at Oklahoma State	2. Immanuel Iheanacho, OT	★★★★★
Sept. 13	at Northwestern	W 34-14	Sept. 19	Portland State	3. Tony Cumberland, DL	★★★★
Sept. 20	Oregon State	W 41-7	Sept. 26	at USC	4. Messiah Hampton, WR	★★★★
Sept. 27	at Penn State (ot)	W 30-24	Oct. 10	UCLA	5. Kendre Harrison, TE	★★★★
Oct. 11	Indiana	L 20-30	Oct. 17	Nebraska	6. Anthony Jones Jr., EDGE	★★★★
Oct. 18	at Rutgers	W 56-10	Oct. 24	at Illinois	7. Devin Jackson, S	★★★★
Oct. 25	Wisconsin	W 21-7	Oct. 31	Northwestern	8. Jett Washington, S	★★★★
Nov. 8	at Iowa	W 18-16	Nov. 7	at Ohio State	9. Davon Benjamin, CB	★★★★
Nov. 14	Minnesota	W 42-13	Nov. 14	Michigan	10. Tommy Tofi, IOL	★★★★
Nov. 22	USC	W 42-27	Nov. 21	at Michigan State		
Nov. 29	at Washington	W 26-14	Nov. 28	Washington		*Per Rivals
Dec. 20	James Madison #	W 51-34	TEAM INFORMATION			
Jan. 1	vs. Texas Tech %	W 23-0	Head Coach: Dan Lanning • Record at School: 48-8 (4 years)			
Jan. 9	vs. Indiana &	L 22-56	Career Record: 48-8 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Drew Mehringer			
#CFB Playoff First Round %Orange Bowl: CFB Playoff Quarterfinal & Peach Bowl: CFB Playoff Semifinal			Defensive Coordinator: Chris Hampton • Location Eugene, Ore.			
			Stadium: Autzen Stadium (54,000)			



DANTE MOORE

SCOUTING THE DUCKS

“That might be the best roster in college foot- ball, with the returners they have on the D-line and the back end, with the addition of Koi Perich from Minnesota — and then offensively, they basically return everyone but Malik Benson, Kenyon Sadiq and a couple running backs, but they played three running backs all year. They lose a couple O-linemen, but I think they feel fine about it. [Dante Moore] was the best quarterback we faced last year. ... With them, the key is going to be how their coordinators put their guys in position to make plays because at no point did I think what they did on defense was super complicated, but it was just so sound and everyone was doing their job at a high level. When you watch them on tape, they look like a team with a lot of 5-stars.”

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	1	DAKORIEN MOORE (SO.)	13	Gatlin Bair (Fr.)
WR	2	Iverson Hooks* (Sr.)		Jalen Lott (Fr.)
WR	3	JEREMIAH MCCLELLAN (SO.)	7	EVAN STEWART (SR.)
LT	59	Fox Crader (So.)	58	Ziyare Addison (Fr.)
LG	74	DAVE IULI (SR.)	73	Kawika Rogers (Sr.)
C	72	IAPANI LALOULU (SR.)	66	Bryce Boulton (Jr.)
RG	55	Douglas Utu (Fr.)	50	Demetri Manning (Fr.)
RT	75	Michael Bennett III* (Sr.)	78	Gernorris Wilson (Jr.)
TE	9	JAMARI JOHNSON (JR.)	18	Kendre Harrison (Fr.)
QB	5	DANTE MOORE (JR.)	8	Dylan Raiola* (Jr.)
RB	0	Jordon Davison (So.)	6	Dierre Hill Jr. (So.)

DEFENSE (8)

DE	10	MATAYO UIAGALELEI (SR.)	42	Aydin Breland (So.)
DT	1	BEAR ALEXANDER (SR.)	55	Matthew Johnson (Fr.)
DT	52	A'MAURI WASHINGTON (SR.)	0	D'Antre Robinson* (Jr.)
OLB	44	TEITUM TUIOTI (SR.)	31	Nasir Wyatt (So.)
ILB	6	JERRY MIXON (SR.)	13	Gavin Nix (Fr.)
ILB	9	Devon Jackson (Sr.)	23	Brayden Platt (So.)
CB	4	BRANDON FINNEY JR. (SO.)	14	Aaron Scott Jr.* (Jr.)
CB	7	IFY OBIDEGWU (SO.)	2	Na'eem Offord (So.)
NB	15	Carl Williams IV* (Jr.)	33	Zach Grisham (Sr.)
S	3	Koi Perich* (Jr.)	12	Peyton Woodyard (Jr.)
S	21	AARON FLOWERS (SO.)	8	Trey McNutt (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	97	Gage Hurych (So.)	KR	3	Koi Perich* (Jr.)
P	39	Bailey Ettridge* (So.)	PR	1	Dakorien Moore (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TONY ROJAS

SCOUTING THE NITTANY LIONS

"I don't necessarily know that they're gonna be immediately good in Year 1, but I thought the three big guys who followed [former defensive coordinator] Jim Knowles to Tennessee went for way more money than I would've paid them if I were Penn State. I thought they made a couple of really good adds. I also thought they kept a couple of really good players that could've left, like [linebacker] Tony Rojas. That's a really good player that probably could've gone anywhere for a lot more money than what he got at Penn State. ... I thought they did really well with their personnel. They obviously took a lot of Iowa State players. That made sense. They took pretty much that whole offensive staff and brought a lot of defensive players from Iowa State. That brings continuity throughout that roster."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	0	Chase Sowell* (Sr.)	15	Keith Jones Jr.* (So.)
WR	4	Brett Eskildsen* (Jr.)	8	Karon Brookins* (Fr.)
WR	6	Koby Howard (So.)	2	Zay Robinson* (Fr.)
LT	78	Malachi Goodman (Fr.)	77	Owen Aliciene (Fr.)
LG	70	Trevor Buhr* (Jr.)	54	Vaea Ikakoula* (Fr.)
C	51	Brock Riker* (So.)	52	Dominic Rulli (Sr.)
RG	50	Cooper Cousins (Jr.)	79	Donnie Harbour (So.)
RT	68	ANTHONY DONKOH (JR.)	71	Garrett Sexton (So.)
TE	18	Benjamin Brahmer* (Sr.)	87	ANDREW RAPPLEYEA (JR.)
QB	3	Rocco Becht* (Sr.)	7	Alex Manske* (Fr.)
RB	21	Carson Hansen* (Sr.)	23	James Peoples* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	33	Alexander McPherson* (So.)	99	Yvan Kemajou (So.)
DT	92	Siale Taupaki* (Sr.)	97	Keanu Williams* (Sr.)
DT	91	Armstrong Nnodim* (So.)	39	Ty Blanding (Jr.)
DE	88	Ikenna Ezeogu* (Sr.)	18	Max Granville (So.)
LB	13	TONY ROJAS (JR.)	25	Alex Tatsch (So.)
LB	10	Caleb Bacon* (Sr.)	9	Cael Brezina* (Jr.)
LB	8	Kooper Ebel* (Sr.)	26	Cam Smith (Fr.)
CB	2	AUDAVION COLLINS (SR.)	7	ZION TRACY (SR.)
CB	5	Daryus Dixon (So.)	23	Jahmir Joseph (Fr.)
S	31	Marcus Neal Jr.* (Jr.)	3	Jamison Patton* (Sr.)
S	4	Jeremiah Cooper* (Sr.)	21	Vaboue Toure (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	94	Ryan Barker (Jr.)	KR	25	Quinton Martin Jr. (So.)
P	38	Nathan Tiyce* (So.)	PR	6	Koby Howard (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



PENN STATE NITTANY LIONS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 18 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 3-6 BIG TEN

OFFENSE New head coach Matt Campbell speaks fondly of his decade at Iowa State, so it's no surprise that six former Cyclones could start for the Nittany Lions, led by quarterback Rocco Becht. A three-year Iowa State starter, Becht is the most experienced FBS quarterback in college football, with 39 career starts, 26 wins and more than 2,500 snaps. He was limited during spring drills while rehabbing from offseason surgery to his non-throwing shoulder but threw in Beaver Stadium with a VR headset.

Becht brought his four favorite targets with him, notably 6-foot-7 tight end Benjamin Brahmer, who will continue the program's recent string of draft picks at the position. Carson Hansen, who rushed for 952 yards for the Cyclones last season, will share running back duties with Ohio State transfer James Peoples.

With four new starters, the offensive line needs a crash course in preseason camp. Still, offensive coordinator Taylor Mouser is comfortable throwing a lot of NFL concepts at the group.

DEFENSE Defensive coordinator D'Anton Lynn, an All-Big Ten cornerback at Penn State, returned to his alma mater after three seasons in Los Angeles (two at USC, one at UCLA). He signed four transfer tackles who weigh at least 319 pounds. The headliner is Siale Taupaki, who played for Lynn at UCLA and is entering his eighth season of college football.

By adding interior size, Lynn seeks to funnel plays to the linebackers. Campbell recruited three from Iowa State, notably Caleb Bacon and Kooper Ebel, who combined for 17.5 tackles for a loss last season. They'll work alongside Tony Rojas, Penn State's top returning defensive player, whose torn ACL before the UCLA game was a turning point.

In the secondary, Campbell has been particularly impressed with Zion Tracy, a Swiss Army knife who can play multiple spots. Former Iowa State safety Marcus Neal Jr. (11 TFLs in 2025) will captain the secondary.

SPECIALISTS Campbell was able to retain kicker Ryan Barker, who led the FBS in field-goal percentage (94.7) last season and didn't miss from inside 50 yards. Special teams coordinator Justin Lustig is back as well after a successful first season with the program.

FINAL ANALYSIS Penn State was fortunate Campbell was available in December. His first season will lean heavily in an Iowa State direction, with 24 of the team's 40 transfers coming from Ames. Becht is a gamer and has the tools to score points. Lynn is reworking a defense that was a huge disappointment last season but has cleaned up the majority of its issues.

Campbell is rebuilding Penn State for long-term viability. A College Football Playoff bid, while possible, would be overachieving this year.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 3-6 BIG TEN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Nevada	W	46-11	Sept. 5	Marshall	1. Elijah Reeder, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 6	FIU	W	34-0	Sept. 12	at Temple	2. Josiah Zayas, ATH	★★★★
Sept. 13	Villanova	W	52-6	Sept. 19	Buffalo	3. Jackson Ford, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 27	Oregon (ot)	L	24-30	Sept. 26	Wisconsin	4. Tyrell Chatman, CB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at UCLA	L	37-42	Oct. 3	at Northwestern	5. Peyton Falzone, QB	★★★
Oct. 11	Northwestern	L	21-22	Oct. 10	USC	6. Bryson Williams, S	★★★
Oct. 18	at Iowa	L	24-25	Oct. 17	at Michigan	7. Mason Bandhauer, OT	★★★
Nov. 1	at Ohio State	L	14-38	Oct. 31	Purdue	8. Amarian Jackson, WR	★★★
Nov. 8	Indiana	L	24-27	Nov. 7	at Washington	9. Ben Whitver, WR	★★★
Nov. 15	at Michigan State	W	28-10	Nov. 14	Minnesota	10. D'Antae Sheffey, RB	★★★
Nov. 22	Nebraska	W	37-10	Nov. 21	Rutgers	*Per Rivals	
Nov. 29	at Rutgers	W	40-36	Nov. 28	at Maryland		
Dec. 27	vs. Clemson #	W	22-10	TEAM INFORMATION			
#Pinstripe Bowl				Head Coach: Matt Campbell • Record at School: First Season Career Record: 107-70 (14+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Taylor Mouser Defensive Coordinator: D'Anton Lynn • Location: University Park, Pa. Stadium: Beaver Stadium (106,304)			



PURDUE BOILERMAKERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 85 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 18 | 2025 RECORD: 2-10, 0-9 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Ryan Browne is back for Year 2 as QB1. He has bulked up to better withstand the rigors of the Big Ten. Browne can make all the throws and can tuck and run — but he needs to be better.

Is there an alpha wideout in the house? Hopes are high for four transfers and a juco. Drops were a big issue in 2025. Injuries have defined George Burhenn's career, but if he can stay healthy, the lithe tight end could be special.

The offensive line received an infusion of size and depth with the addition of six portal linemen. But the best of the blockers is holdover tackle Joey Tanona. It's hoped that a beefier line and new OL coach (Zach Crabtree) will pave the way for a promising collection of backs. Keep an eye on Minnesota transfer Fame Ijeboi and Texas transfer Jerrick Gibson.

DEFENSE It was a bit of a surprise when Purdue brought back Kevin Kane to reprise his role as defensive coordinator, a position he held for the Boilermakers for two disastrous years under former head coach Ryan Walters. Kane has a lot to prove for a defense that ranked 17th in the Big Ten in total defense last year and has allowed at least 30 points per game each of the past three seasons. The unquestioned leader: linebacker Charles Correa, the ultimate warrior.

Questions loom for a secondary that has six portal additions along with two juco transfers. Hudaori Hines and Don Saunders, a Utah transfer, should form a nice CB duo. Is there a pass-rusher in the house? All eyes are on Georgia transfer Elo Modozie and juco transfer Jeremy Lewis. The tackle tandem of TJ Lindsey and Ian Jeffries has potential.

SPECIALISTS Lots to sort out here. Purdue is auditioning kickers and punters, and fingers are crossed. Big things are expected from diminutive FCS Jackson State transfer Travis Terrell Jr. in the return game. He is quick and elusive. Purdue feels that special teams coach James Shibest gives them a schematic edge.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Barry Odom couldn't stop the bleeding during his maiden voyage last year, when he went 2-10 (0-9 Big Ten). How bad have things been in West Lafayette? The program is riding an 18-game Big Ten losing streak and has gone 3-21 overall the past two seasons with no victories over Power 4 opponents. The last Big Ten win? It was in 2023. You get the picture. Odom has set his jaw and swears this will be a bowl team. An easier schedule will help. The hope is that the arrival of 29 portal players and four juco transfers brings instant results and improvement for a beleaguered program in the midst of its worst stretch in school history.

2025 RESULTS (2-10, 0-9 BIG TEN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Ball State	W	31-0	Sept. 5	Indiana State	1. Josiah Hope, DL	★★★
Sept. 6	Southern Illinois	W	34-17	Sept. 12	Wake Forest	2. Izaiah Wright, RB	★★★
Sept. 13	USC	L	17-33	Sept. 19	at UCLA	3. Brock Brownfield, IOL	★★★
Sept. 20	at Notre Dame	L	30-56	Sept. 26	Notre Dame	4. Maximilian Carmicle, DL	★★★
Oct. 4	Illinois	L	27-43	Oct. 3	at Illinois	5. Jett Goldsberry, S	★★★
Oct. 11	at Minnesota	L	20-27	Oct. 10	Minnesota	6. Ar'Mari Towns, TE	★★★
Oct. 18	at Northwestern	L	0-19	Oct. 17	Washington	7. Katrell Webb, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 25	Rutgers	L	24-27	Oct. 31	at Penn State	8. Raderion Daniels, CB	★★★
Nov. 1	at Michigan	L	16-21	Nov. 7	Maryland	9. James Williams Jr., IOL	★★★
Nov. 8	Ohio State	L	10-34	Nov. 14	at Iowa	10. Ricky Sampson, WR	★★★
Nov. 15	at Washington	L	13-49	Nov. 21	Wisconsin		
Nov. 28	Indiana	L	3-56	Nov. 28	at Indiana		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Barry Odom • Record at School: 2-10 (1 year) • Career Record: 46-43 (7 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Josh Henson • Defensive Coordinator: Kevin Kane • Location: West Lafayette, Ind. • Stadium: Ross-Ade Stadium (61,441)



RYAN BROWNE

SCOUTING THE BOILERMAKERS

"Some continuity definitely helps [head coach] Barry Odom in Year 2. Truthfully, I wasn't incredibly impressed with what they brought in through the transfer portal. At Purdue, you have such an avenue to offer playing time to guys when other schools that you're gonna play against that aren't that much better than you can't do that. I don't think they took great advantage of that, but I definitely think they'll be better from a continuity standpoint. ... I really do think that they have a good coaching staff, but I'd be lying if I said that I was impressed with what they brought in through the portal."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	3	Xavier Townsend* (Sr.)	8	De'Nylon Morrisette (Sr.)
WR	19	Asaad Waseem* (Jr.)	10	Jesse Watson (So.)
WR		Bisi Owens* (Sr.)	80	Brandon Kinsey (Fr.)
LT	79	JOEY TANONA (SR.)	72	Jude McCoskey (Sr.)
LG	56	Marques Easley (So.)	55	Marc Nave Jr. (So.)
C	50	Boaz Stanley* (Sr.)	76	Ethan Trent (Jr.)
RG	59	Micah Banuelos* (Jr.)	73	Makai Saina* (So.)
RT	68	Nuku Mafi* (So.)	77	Jatavius Shivers* (Jr.)
TE	81	George Burhenn (Jr.)	16	Kylan Fox* (Jr.)
QB	15	RYAN BROWNE (JR.)	1	Evans Chuba (So.)
RB	2	Fame Ijeboi* (So.)	4	Jerrick Gibson* (So.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	18	Elo Modozie* (Sr.)	33	Jeremy Lewis (Jr.)
DT	9	TJ Lindsey (So.)	92	Curt Neal* (Sr.)
DT	40	IAN JEFFRIES (JR.)	97	Wisdom Simms* (Sr.)
DE	23	Trey Smith (Jr.)	8	CJ MADDEN (SR.)
LB	5	CHARLES CORREA (JR.)	16	Anthony Spec* (Jr.)
LB	0	Jojo Hayden* (Jr.)	20	Winston Berglund (Jr.)
CB	4	HUDAURI HINES (JR.)	12	Ryan Turner (Sr.)
CB	7	Don Saunders* (Sr.)	29	Dee Newsome* (Jr.)
NB	1	Smiley Bradford (Jr.)	6	Mister Clark* (Jr.)
S	13	John Slaughter* (Sr.)	10	Ta'Vari Hampton (So.)
S	2	Jaden Mangham* (Sr.)	21	Justin Denson Jr.* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	45	Seth Turner (Jr.)	KR	20	Travis Terrell Jr.* (Jr.)
P	42	Dylan Drennan* (So.)	PR	20	Travis Terrell Jr.* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

MATT KROHN-IMAGN IMAGES



ANTWAN RAYMOND

SCOUTING THE SCARLET KNIGHTS

"I get the sense that the school thinks they're actually going to make this investment and give [head coach] Greg Schiano a chance to get it done because they have not done that yet. The people there know that he's basically been fighting that fight with a hand tied behind his back. ... Schiano is an excellent coach. He works incredibly hard. But at some point, it's a results business, so I would imagine that the rubber meets the road in the next year or so if they can't make a turn. But they were just not talented on defense last year. You turn on the tape, and they didn't have anybody that could do anything. That's a program problem. If you're in the Big Ten, and you're unable to recruit good players into your program, it's gonna be tough."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	8	KJ DUFF (JR.)	5	Vernon Allen III (So.)
WR	2	Ben Black (Jr.)	1	Famah Toure (Sr.)
WR	0	Dyzier Carter (Fr.)	4	Jourdin Houston (So.)
LT	68	Ryder Langsdale (Sr.)	74	Moshood Giwa (Jr.)
LG	76	Dantae Chin (Jr.)	55	Nick Oliveira (Jr.)
C	53	Hank Zilinskas (Sr.)	57	Isaiah Cook* (Sr.)
RG	69	KWABENA ASAMOAH (SR.)	67	Chris Vigna (So.)
RT	56	TYLER NEEDHAM (SR.)	54	Everett Small* (Jr.)
TE	11	Logan Blake (Sr.)	88	Mike Higgins (Sr.)
QB	10	AJ Surace (So.)	12	Dylan Loneragan* (Jr.)
RB	3	ANTWAN RAYMOND (JR.)	9	Clay Thevenin* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	11	Malachi Davis* (Sr.)	90	Farell Gnago (Jr.)
DT	99	Rondo Porter* (Jr.)	55	ZAIRE ANGOY (SR.)
DT	0	Doug Blue-Eli (Sr.)	96	Keshon Griffin (Sr.)
DE	94	J'Dan Burnett* (Sr.)	8	Wydeek Collier-Johnson (Fr.)
LB	2	MOSES WALKER (SR.)	10	Ty Morris* (Sr.)
LB	6	ABRAM WRIGHT (SR.)	13	DJ McClary (So.)
CB	12	Zahmir Dawud* (Sr.)	22	Michael Clayton (So.)
CB	4	Kevyn Humes* (Jr.)	5	Bradlee Jones* (Sr.)
NB	7	Kevin Levy (Jr.)	27	Sage Clawges (Sr.)
S	9	DK Gilley (Jr.)	16	Jesse Ofurie (Sr.)
S	1	KAJ SANDERS (JR.)	20	Chris Joines (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	44	Jai Patel (Sr.)	KR	2	Ben Black (Jr.)
P	94	Jakob Anderson (Jr.)	PR	2	Ben Black (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



RUTGERS SCARLET KNIGHTS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 69 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 16 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 2-7 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Rutgers must replace starting quarterback Athan Kaliakmanis, who exhausted his eligibility after two of the best years at the position in program history. The Scarlet Knights will choose between rising redshirt sophomore AJ Surace, who was Kaliakmanis' backup for two years, and Boston College transfer Dylan Loneragan, a former 4-star recruit who was handpicked by Nick Saban at Alabama.

The Scarlet Knights retained their top two stars in running back Antwan Raymond and wide receiver KJ Duff, who should be one of the best players in the Big Ten this season, but they lost depth at wide receiver with Ian Strong's transfer to Cal and DT Sheffield's graduation. Competition for the two spots behind Duff should be strong among a number of returnees and talented incoming freshmen.

The offensive line is in flux, with starters Gus Zilinskas (center) and Bryan Felter (left guard) having graduated. Kwabena Asamoah is a lock to start at right guard, but the two tackle spots and left guard were wide open in the spring. New offensive line coach Jim Turner, who replaces two-time Super Bowl champion Pat Flaherty, has a lot to sort out.

DEFENSE Looking to upgrade the worst Rutgers defense in the Big Ten era, head coach Greg Schiano revamped his coaching staff, firing co-coordinators Robb Smith and Zach Sparber and replacing them with FCS South Dakota head coach Travis Johansen. Johansen then hired a number of familiar faces from his lower-level stops to fill out the rest of his staff.

There will be multiple key position battles. Cornerback should be the "most competitive" of the bunch, per Schiano, as all three starting spots will feature new faces. Rutgers will look to strengthen its interior line with the return of Doug Blue-Eli, who missed last season with injury, and coaches hope that one of the defensive end transfers could be the first Scarlet Knight to collect five sacks in a season in a decade.

SPECIALISTS Rutgers is returning its starting kicker (Jai Patel), punter (Jakob Anderson) and long-snapper (Michael O'Connor) from a unit that was solid last season. The Scarlet Knights fair-catch a majority of punts and kick returns, but they remain very aggressive in trying to block kicks.

FINAL ANALYSIS Rutgers brought back two of the best offensive weapons in the Big Ten, has depth at wide receiver and should be better defensively than last year's debacle. But between replacing one of their greatest quarterbacks ever, the many unknowns on defense and a lot of movement on the offensive line, there are enough question marks to make earning a bowl bid — the minimum expectation for the Scarlet Knights in Year 7 of Schiano's second stint at the school — far from a guarantee.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 2-7 BIG TEN)

Aug. 28	Ohio	W	34-31
Sept. 6	Miami (Ohio)	W	45-17
Sept. 13	Norfolk State	W	60-10
Sept. 19	Iowa	L	28-38
Sept. 27	at Minnesota	L	28-31
Oct. 10	at Washington	L	19-38
Oct. 18	Oregon	L	10-56
Oct. 25	at Purdue	W	27-24
Nov. 1	at Illinois	L	13-35
Nov. 8	Maryland	W	35-20
Nov. 22	at Ohio State	L	9-42
Nov. 29	Penn State	L	36-40

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 3	UMass
Sept. 11	at Boston College
Sept. 19	USC
Sept. 26	Howard
Oct. 3	Indiana
Oct. 17	at Maryland
Oct. 24	at Northwestern
Oct. 31	Michigan
Nov. 7	at Wisconsin
Nov. 14	Nebraska
Nov. 21	at Penn State
Nov. 28	Michigan State

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Devonte Anderson, CB	★★★★
2.	Rinaldo Callaway III, EDGE	★★★★
3.	Logan Anthony, IOL	★★★★
4.	Messiah Tilson, S	★★★
5.	Reece Beck, EDGE	★★★
6.	Brandon Murray, CB	★★★
7.	Xavier Stearn, QB	★★★
8.	Jared Smith, IOL	★★★
9.	Dyzier Carter, WR	★★★
10.	JJ Conyers, CB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Greg Schiano • Record at School: 99-108 (17 years) • Career Record: 99-108 (17 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Kirk Ciarrocca • Defensive Coordinator: Travis Johansen • Location: New Brunswick, N.J. • Stadium: SHI Stadium (52,454)

OFFENSE UCLA has a new head coach (Bob Chesney) and an influx of transfers but a returning quarterback in Nico Iamaleava, who has made big portal news before but chose to stay in Westwood. Iamaleava struggled at times during his UCLA transition but also displayed immense talent and completed 64.4% of passes while adding 505 rushing yards.

"He's not timid, he's not afraid, he's not sitting back there wondering what to do," Chesney says. "He has a good grasp of the offense. He's very capable physically. He loves this game, and he's not humble out there."

Iamaleava will throw to a transfer-heavy receiver group with speed and a willingness to block. San José State transfer Leland Smith and Landon Ellis, who joined Chesney from James Madison, should lead the group alongside Power 4 transfers Brian Rowe (South Carolina) and Semaj Morgan (Michigan).

Running back projects well with Wayne Knight, a star at JMU, joining returnee Anthony Woods. UCLA will need a transfer tight end to emerge. The offensive line features portal pickups like tackle Jordan Davis (South Alabama) and guard Riley Robell (James Madison) as well as a key returnee in guard Eugene Brooks.

DEFENSE The secondary is the unit's strength, as safety Cole Martin, cornerback Rodrick Pleasant and nickel Scooter Jackson return. They will be joined by potential impact transfers like Utah safety Tao Johnson, whom Chesney calls "a phenomenal football player," and James Madison nickel DJ Barksdale.

The Bruins have an intriguing linebacker tandem in returnee Jalen Woods and Oklahoma transfer Samuel Omosigho, who had 50 tackles and two sacks last season. "A really commanding presence," Chesney says.

The defensive line is almost completely new. Sun Belt Freshman of the Year Sahir West and Aiden Gobaira both made the move out West from James Madison. Power 4 imports like Darold DeNoghe (Rutgers), Tyson Ford (Cal) and Maxwell Roy (Ohio State) will be in the rotation.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Mateen Bhaghani has connected on 83% of his career field-goal attempts, including 39-of-45 inside 50 yards. UCLA added transfer punter Curtis Gerrand, who averaged 43 yards for Sam Houston last season. Knight averaged 9.5 yards per punt return in 2025.

FINAL ANALYSIS Chesney enters the Big Ten with a largely overhauled roster, and UCLA needs the new pieces to click — especially along both lines and at receiver. The Bruins begin with challenging nonleague games against Cal and San Diego State, but their conference slate isn't particularly grueling until November. The JMU transfers and Iamaleava create a chance for Year 1 success.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 3-6 BIG TEN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Utah L 10-43	Sept. 5 at Cal	1. Quinn Buckley, OT ★★★★★
Sept. 6 at UNLV L 23-30	Sept. 12 San Diego State	2. Kenneth Moore III, WR ★★★
Sept. 12 New Mexico L 10-35	Sept. 19 Purdue	3. James Moffat, DL ★★★
Sept. 27 at Northwestern L 14-17	Sept. 26 at Maryland	4. Cooper Javorsky, IOL ★★★
Oct. 4 Penn State W 42-37	Oct. 10 at Oregon	5. Jayden Fox, RB ★★★
Oct. 11 at Michigan State W 38-13	Oct. 17 Wisconsin	6. Camden Jensen, TE ★★★
Oct. 18 Maryland W 20-17	Oct. 24 Michigan State	7. DJ Bordeaux, QB ★★★
Oct. 25 at Indiana L 6-56	Oct. 31 Nevada	8. Logan Hirou, S ★★★
Nov. 8 Nebraska L 21-28	Nov. 7 at Minnesota	9. Mike McDonald, IOL ★★★
Nov. 15 at Ohio State L 10-48	Nov. 14 Illinois	10. Zaheer Young, OT ★★★
Nov. 22 Washington L 14-48	Nov. 21 at Michigan	
Nov. 29 at USC L 10-29	Nov. 28 USC	

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Bob Chesney • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 132-52 (16 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Dean Kennedy • Defensive Coordinator: Colin Hitschler • Location: Los Angeles, Calif. • Stadium: Rose Bowl (89,702)



NICO IAMALEAVA

SCOUTING THE BRUINS

"If I was going to defend [QB Nico Iamaleava], I would do some things to stop him from running and make him throw the ball — particularly downfield. He's a playmaker. But without his feet and without his ability to scramble, I'm not sure that he can sit in the pocket and carve you up. It'll be interesting to see what the NFL guys think of him. He's a good player and can take a hit, but he just didn't seem like he could kill you with his arm. ... I was blown away with what their NIL budget was a few years ago. It was unfathomably low. I don't know if they've gotten that ramped up. ... I've heard they've been kind of arrogant on the road with following the [Curt] Cignetti model. Like, 'Look who we are,' instead of saying, 'We're gonna do this the right way.' I'm interested to see how [new head coach Bob Chesney] does, though."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	0	Leland Smith* (Sr.)	1	Aidan Mizell* (Jr.)
WR	2	Brian Rowe* (So.)	7	Mikey Matthews (Sr.)
WR	11	Landon Ellis* (Sr.)	4	Semaj Morgan* (Sr.)
LT	68	Jordan Davis* (Sr.)	76	Mack Indestad* (Sr.)
LG	55	EUGENE BROOKS (SO.)	74	Julian Armella (Sr.)
C	64	SAM YOON (SR.)	54	Derek Osman* (Sr.)
RG	52	Carter Sweazie* (Sr.)	51	Riley Robell* (Jr.)
RT	65	Hall Schmidt* (Sr.)	78	Mike McDonald* (So.)
TE	85	Brayden Loftin* (Sr.)	89	Josh Phifer* (Jr.)
QB	9	NICO IAMALEAVA (JR.)	10	Madden Iamaleava (Fr.)
RB	3	Wayne Knight* (Sr.)	6	Anthony Woods (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	15	Sahir West* (So.)	33	Dallin Havea* (So.)
DT	92	Darold DeNoghe* (Sr.)	55	AJ Fuimaono (Jr.)
DT	99	Maxwell Roy* (Fr.)	95	Tyson Ford* (Jr.)
DE	97	Aiden Gobaira* (Sr.)	19	Ryan McCulloch* (Jr.)
LB	9	Jalen Woods (Sr.)	0	Donavyn Pellott (Fr.)
LB	10	Samuel Omosigho* (Sr.)	56	Drew Spinogatti* (Sr.)
CB	3	Robert Stafford III (Jr.)	21	Dante Lovett* (Jr.)
CB	2	RODRICK PLEASANT (JR.)	18	Osiris Gilbert* (So.)
NB	1	SCOOTER JACKSON (SR.)	32	DJ Barksdale* (Sr.)
S	4	COLE MARTIN (SR.)	27	Ta'Shawn James* (Jr.)
S	6	Tao Johnson* (Sr.)	12	Malik Hartford* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	15	Mateen Bhaghani (Sr.)	KR	7	Mikey Matthews (Sr.)
P	35	Curtis Gerrand* (So.)	PR	3	Wayne Knight* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



JAYDEN MAIAVA

SCOUTING THE TROJANS

"The defensive questions are very much there, but they're also recruiting to the point where it wouldn't surprise me to see those questions answered. They have enough talent to be real competitors in the conference. That's the beauty of the Big Ten. You can be fifth and be on the borderline to make the playoff. It wouldn't surprise me if they did that. If I were setting the odds, I would view it as damn near 50-50 as to whether they're gonna get to the playoff. ... They recruited really, really well on both lines of scrimmage the last couple classes. At the high school level, they're hoarding a lot of the big bodies. They may have a freshman or two start on the offensive line with how they recruited, and then a player like [defensive lineman] Jahkeem Stewart is one of the more unbelievable guys you'll scout."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (9)

WR	16	TANOOK HINES (SO.)	17	Kayden Dixon-Wyatt (Fr.)
WR	9	Terrell Anderson* (Jr.)	18	Romero Ison (Fr.)
WR	0	Zacharyus Williams (So.)	10	Corey Simms (So.)
LT	72	ELIJAH PAIGE (JR.)	79	Elijah Vaikona (Fr.)
LG	73	TOBIAS RAYMOND (JR.)	68	Hayden Treter (So.)
C	67	KILIAN O'CONNOR (SR.)	52	Willi Wascher (Fr.)
RG	77	ALANI NOA (SR.)	60	Kaylon Miller (So.)
RT	74	JUSTIN TAUANUU (SO.)	71	Keenyi Pepe (Fr.)
TE	87	Josiah Jefferson (Jr.)	19	Mark Bowman (Fr.)
QB	14	JAYDEN MAIAVA (SR.)	7	Sam Huard (Sr.)
RB	2	WAYMOND JORDAN (SR.)	8	KING MILLER (SO.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	10	Braylan Shelby (Sr.)	18	Zuriah Fisher* (Sr.)
DT	97	JIDE ABASIRI (JR.)	88	Floyd Boucard (So.)
DT	4	Jahkeem Stewart (So.)	99	Jamaal Jarrett (Jr.)
DE	1	KAMERYN CRAWFORD (JR.)	94	Luke Waffle (Fr.)
LB	17	Deven Bryant* (Jr.)	15	Jadyn Walker (So.)
LB	8	DESMAN STEPHENS II (JR.)	26	Elijah Newby (So.)
CB	0	Jontez Williams* (Sr.)	16	Prophet Brown (Sr.)
CB	25	MARCELLES WILLIAMS (SO.)	27	Chasen Johnson (So.)
NB	7	Alex Graham (Fr.)	2	Elbert Hill IV (Fr.)
S	6	CHRISTIAN PIERCE (SR.)	30	Marquis Gallegos (So.)
S	9	Kennedy Urlacher (Jr.)	38	Isaiah Rubin (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	48	Ryon Sayeri (So.)	KR	16	Tanook Hines (So.)
P	35	Lachlan Carrigan* (So.)	PR	4	Trent Mosley (Fr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



USC TROJANS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 14 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 7-2 BIG TEN

OFFENSE USC returns one of the nation's most efficient quarterbacks in Jayden Maiava, an offensive line loaded with experience and a gifted running back tandem in Waymond Jordan and King Miller, who combined to average 6.3 yards per rush in 2025. All five starters up front return, anchored by tackles Elijah Paige and Justin Tauanuu, as USC seeks continued improvement in the run game.

"If we can keep these guys healthy, this group will have the opportunity to be the most dominant that we've had," head coach Lincoln Riley says of his O-line. "Closing out those tough road games and winning these championship games, that's the next step. A lot of that will lean on our line and on our backs."

Maiava finished fifth nationally in passing yards (3,711) and second in QBR (89.9) last season. He will throw to a mostly different group, as USC loses Biletnikoff Award winner Makai Lemon, All-Big Ten tight end Lake McRee and wideout J'Kobi Lane. USC brings back Tanook Hines, adds NC State transfer Terrell Anderson and welcomes in decorated recruits like receiver Boobie Feaster and tight end Mark Bowman.

DEFENSE Hall of Famer Gary Patterson, the former head coach at TCU, takes over a defense with elevated expectations, especially with increased depth up front. USC's defensive line was the group that Riley said had the furthest to go when he arrived. The front now features greater depth at both spots with players like ends Braylan Shelby and Kameryn Crawford, tackles Jide Abasiri and Jahkeem Stewart and transfers like end Zuriah Fisher (Penn State). Riley also likes the depth at cornerback, where Marcelles Williams is back, Prophet Brown and Chasen Johnson return from injury and transfer Jontez Williams (Iowa State) arrives.

The Trojans must replace All-America safety Bishop Fitzgerald but return Christian Pierce, nickel Alex Graham and others.

SPECIALISTS New special teams coordinator Mike Ekeler arrives from Nebraska to oversee a group that returns standout kicker Ryon Sayeri while adding Memphis transfer Lachlan Carrigan at punter. Lemon also handled most of the returns, so Hines, Trent Mosley and others figure to be bigger factors in that department.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Trojans' roster is less plug-and-play and more home-grown, bolstered by line depth, talented backs, a potentially elite quarterback in Maiava and an influx from one of the nation's top recruiting classes, which is comprised of players who will contribute without being totally relied upon. "The roster has improved drastically in the last couple of years," Riley says. "It's primed to take that next step."

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 7-2 BIG TEN)

Aug. 30	Missouri State	W	73-13
Sept. 6	Georgia Southern	W	59-20
Sept. 13	at Purdue	W	33-17
Sept. 20	Michigan State	W	45-31
Sept. 27	at Illinois	L	32-34
Oct. 11	Michigan	W	31-13
Oct. 18	at Notre Dame	L	24-34
Nov. 1	at Nebraska	W	21-17
Nov. 7	Northwestern	W	38-17
Nov. 15	Iowa	W	26-21
Nov. 22	at Oregon	L	27-42
Nov. 29	UCLA	W	29-10
Dec. 30	vs. TCU # (ot)	L	27-30

#Alamo Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Aug. 29	San José State
Sept. 5	Fresno State
Sept. 12	Louisiana
Sept. 19	at Rutgers
Sept. 26	Oregon
Oct. 3	Washington
Oct. 10	at Penn State
Oct. 24	at Wisconsin
Oct. 31	Ohio State
Nov. 14	at Indiana
Nov. 21	Maryland
Nov. 28	at UCLA

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Luke Waffle, EDGE	★★★★★
2. Jaimeon Winfield, DL	★★★★★
3. Kayden Dixon-Wyatt, WR	★★★★★
4. Mark Bowman, TE	★★★★★
5. Vlad Dyakonov, OT	★★★★★
6. Boobie Feaster, WR	★★★★★
7. Elbert Hill IV, CB	★★★★★
8. Deshonnie Redeaux, RB	★★★★★
9. Shahn Alston, RB	★★★★★
10. Talanoa Ili, LB	★★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Lincoln Riley • Record at School: 35-18 (4 years)
Career Record: 90-28 (9 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Luke Huard
Defensive Coordinator: Gary Patterson • Location: Los Angeles, Calif.
Stadium: Los Angeles Memorial Coliseum (77,500)



WASHINGTON HUSKIES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 17 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 5-4 BIG TEN

OFFENSE Washington took a massive step forward on offense in 2025, rocketing up the ranks of the Big Ten to No. 4 in scoring offense (34.1 points per game) and No. 5 in total offense (409.9 yards per game). With junior quarterback Demond Williams Jr. back in the fold after his brief flirtation with the transfer portal, head coach Jedd Fisch is looking for his unit to take another step forward.

However, Williams is going to have to do it without his best weapons. Wide receiver Denzel Boston and running back Jonah Coleman departed for the NFL Draft, as did left tackle Carver Willis, while running back Adam Mohammed and wide receiver Raiden Vines-Bright both hit the portal. But with four starters returning along the offensive line, Washington is very confident after reeling in the highest-rated recruiting class in school history.

The Huskies are projecting big roles for 4-star recruits Jordan Clay, Mason James and Trez Davis at wide receiver, while running back Brian Bonner Jr. is expected to be part of the rotation at an inexperienced position. Left tackle Kodi Greene, a 5-star recruit, is expected to start right away and give the offense a boost.

DEFENSE Defensive coordinator Ryan Walters has similar expectations for the youth on his defense, which includes an overhaul of the defensive line. Led by junior Elinneus Davis, 4-star freshman Derek Colman-Brusa and a trio of transfers in DeSean Watts, Darin Conley and Kai McClendon, the line should be stout against the run and in rushing the passer.

The Huskies can also boast one of the nation's best linebacking corps, including seniors Jacob Manu and Xe'ree Alexander and sophomore Zaydrius Rainey-Sale. The secondary features All-Big Ten honorable mention selection Alex McLaughlin and Freshman All-American Rylon Dillard-Allen at safety, and cornerbacks Emmanuel Karnley, a Virginia transfer, and sophomore Dylan Robinson, who has "first-round traits" according to the staff.

SPECIALISTS Coordinator Chris Petrilli added second-team All-Sun Belt kicker Tyler Robles, who converted on 91.3% of his field goals (21-for-23) at Texas State. Washington needed to upgrade at punter and landed one of the nation's best in Hunter Green from San Diego State, who ranked No. 6 in the nation in average yards per punt last season at 47.0.

FINAL ANALYSIS The schedule includes a few tough road trips — USC, Nebraska, Oregon — but if Williams can take a step forward after struggles in the big moments last year, Washington should be able to get to 10 wins and potentially knock on the door of the College Football Playoff.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 5-4 BIG TEN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Colorado State	W	38-21	Sept. 5	Washington State	1. Kodi Greene, OT	★★★★
Sept. 6	UC Davis	W	70-10	Sept. 12	Utah State	2. Rajsjon Duncan, CB	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Washington State	W	59-24	Sept. 19	E. Washington	3. Brian Bonner Jr., RB	★★★★
Sept. 27	Ohio State	L	6-24	Sept. 26	Minnesota	4. JD Hill, DL	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Maryland	W	24-20	Oct. 3	at USC	5. Derek Colman-Brusa, DL	★★★★
Oct. 10	Rutgers	W	38-19	Oct. 10	Iowa	6. Trez Davis, WR	★★★★
Oct. 18	at Michigan	L	7-24	Oct. 17	at Purdue	7. Ramzak Fruean, LB	★★★★
Oct. 25	Illinois	W	42-25	Oct. 31	at Nebraska	8. Gavin Day, S	★★★★
Nov. 8	at Wisconsin	L	10-13	Nov. 7	Penn State	9. Mason James, WR	★★★
Nov. 15	Purdue	W	49-13	Nov. 14	at Michigan State	10. Jordan Clay, WR	★★★
Nov. 22	at UCLA	W	48-14	Nov. 21	Indiana		
Nov. 29	Oregon	L	14-26	Nov. 28	at Oregon		*Per Rivals
Dec. 13	vs. Boise State #	W	38-10				
#LA Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Jedd Fisch • Record at School: 15-11 (2 years)			
				Career Record: 32-33 (5+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jedd Fisch			
				Defensive Coordinator: Ryan Walters • Location: Seattle, Wash.			
				Stadium: Husky Stadium (70,083)			



DEMOND WILLIAMS JR.

SCOUTING THE HUSKIES

"They can recruit better at the high school level, which would help them get there. I almost see them in the same light as Minnesota. They're not a dark horse, but they'll be a top-half team. I definitely think talent is a part of that. ... It was assumed that [quarterback Demond Williams Jr.] was going to LSU when he entered the transfer portal. You got the sense pretty early on that after LSU missed out on [Cincinnati transfer quarterback Brendan Sorsby], they were pretty desperate. But it wouldn't have made a lot of sense for [Williams] to leave Washington, and once it came out that his agency cut ties with him because of it, there was no way that was gonna happen."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	5	Christian Moss* (Sr.)	11	Jordan Clay (Fr.)
WR	2	DEZMEN ROEBUCK (SO.)	6	Mason James (Fr.)
WR	3	Rashid Williams (Jr.)	8	Chris Lawson (So.)
LT	76	Kodi Greene (Fr.)	55	Kolt Dieterich* (Jr.)
LG	72	JOHN MILLS (SO.)	78	Jake Flores (Fr.)
C	66	LANDEN HATCHETT (SR.)	56	GEIREAN HATCHETT (SR.)
RG	73	Champ Taulealea (Fr.)	75	Lowen Colman-Brusa (Fr.)
RT	74	DREW AZZOPARDI (SR.)	68	Soane Faasolo (Jr.)
TE	86	DECKER DEGRAAF (JR.)	85	Baron Naone (So.)
QB	1	DEMOND WILLIAMS JR. (JR.)	10	Treston McMillan (Fr.)
RB	4	Jordan Washington (So.)	17	Jayden Limar* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DT	5	Derek Colman-Brusa (Fr.)	58	DeSean Watts* (Jr.)
DT	90	ELINNEUS DAVIS (JR.)	33	Darin Conley* (Jr.)
OLB	12	Logan George* (Jr.)	52	Devin Hyde (So.)
ILB	23	Zaydrius Rainey-Sale (So.)	10	Xe'ree Alexander (Sr.)
ILB	9	Jacob Manu (Sr.)	0	TAARIQ AL-UQDAH (JR.)
OLB	48	JACOB LANE (SR.)	99	Russell Davis II (Sr.)
HUSKY	2	Rahshawn Clark (So.)	16	Ramonz Adams Jr. (Fr.)
CB	8	Emmanuel Karnley* (Jr.)		Rajsjon Duncan (Fr.)
CB	6	Dylan Robinson (So.)	24	Jeron Jones (Fr.)
S	7	ALEX MCLAUGHLIN (SR.)	4	CJ Christian (Sr.)
S	3	Rylon Dillard-Allen (So.)	21	Gavin Day (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Tyler Robles* (Jr.)	KR	4	Jordan Washington (So.)
P	93	Hunter Green* (Sr.)	PR	2	Rahshawn Clark (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

JAYNE KAMIN-ONCEA-IMAGN IMAGES



MASON POSA

SCOUTING THE BADGERS

"They scored 81 points in nine conference games. I don't care who your quarterback is. That speaks to a lot of bigger issues than just the quarterback position. There are teams in the conference who could not throw a single pass and score more than nine points per game. It also speaks to, defensively, your ability to make turnovers, and special teams, your ability to make kicks. I thought it was a whole package thing. ... Truthfully, I was surprised that both Wisconsin and Maryland decided to run it back with their head coaches. I wasn't really impressed with either one of those teams. It almost felt like they didn't really know who the next guy was gonna be, so they decided they'd rather have a year to prepare a move like that."

— An opposing Big Ten assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	2	CHRIS BROOKS JR. (SR.)	7	Shamar Rigby* (Jr.)
WR	9	Jaylon Domingeaux* (Sr.)	16	Malachi Coleman* (Jr.)
WR	0	Tyrell Henry (Sr.)	13	Eugene Hilton Jr. (So.)
LT	71	PJ Wilkins* (Jr.)	72	Lucas Simmons-Johansson* (Jr.)
LG	78	COLIN CUBBERLY (SO.)	50	Ryan Cory (So.)
C	51	Austin Kawecki* (Sr.)	76	Stylz Blackmon* (Jr.)
RG	75	EMERSON MANDELL (SO.)	73	Blake Cherry* (So.)
RT	55	Kevin Heywood (So.)	60	Nolan Davenport (Fr.)
TE	82	Emmett Bork (Fr.)	89	Jacob Harris* (Jr.)
QB	1	Colton Joseph* (Jr.)	8	Deuce Adams* (So.)
RB	3	Abu Sama III* (Sr.)	6	Darrion Dupree (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	30	Charles Perkins (Sr.)	99	Junior Poyser* (Jr.)
DT	91	Hammond Russell IV* (Sr.)	92	Nolan Vils (Jr.)
SLB	15	Sebastian Cheeks (Sr.)	12	Nicolas Clayton (So.)
ILB	44	COOPER CATALANO (SO.)	19	Thomas Heiberger (So.)
ILB	8	MASON POSA (SO.)	28	Jon Jon Kamara* (So.)
JACK	7	Tyrese Fearbry (Sr.)	51	Micheal Garner (Sr.)
CB	2	Javan Robinson* (Sr.)	1	Eric Fletcher Jr.* (So.)
CB	24	Jai'mier Scott (Fr.)	3	Cai Bates* (So.)
NB	5	Bryce West* (So.)	27	Raphael Dunn (So.)
SS	29	MATTHEW JUNG (SR.)	13	Matthew Traynor (Jr.)
FS	4	Marvin Burks Jr.* (Sr.)	21	Cairo Skanes (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	97	Gavin Lahm (Sr.)	KR	0	Tyrell Henry (Sr.)
P	91	Sean West (So.)	PR	0	Tyrell Henry (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



WISCONSIN BADGERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 55 | BIG TEN PREDICTION: 13 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-7 BIG TEN

OFFENSE The Badgers are pinning their hopes on a transfer quarterback for the fourth consecutive season under head coach Luke Fickell. Former Old Dominion QB and Sun Belt Offensive Player of the Year Colton Joseph will take over with the hope that his rushing ability and downfield passing will inject Wisconsin's offense with much-needed explosiveness. Wisconsin finished last season with the worst passing offense and the worst scoring offense in the Power 4 and failed to generate shots down the field. Joseph excelled at such plays at ODU and is expected to take advantage of play-action snaps that create one-on-one situations for receivers.

Every position on the offense got a facelift through the transfer portal, most notably the offensive line, a group that has failed to be the program's calling card of late as it was in the past. Former Iowa State running back Abu Sama III and USC back Bryan Jackson II arrived to bolster a backfield that fell apart down the stretch of 2025. Joseph had more runs of 10 or more yards (37) than Wisconsin did as a team (33) last season.

DEFENSE Linebackers Cooper Catalano and Mason Posa were major retention wins for the Badgers after the pair emerged as freshmen to lead the defense. Wisconsin recruited multiple inside linebackers to ensure it could deploy Posa as a pass-rusher and in other situational roles to get him near the ball as often as possible.

Transfer cornerbacks Cai Bates, Eric Fletcher Jr., Javan Robinson and Bryce West all figure to be major pieces, and Missouri transfer Marvin Burks Jr. gives the safety group the experience it lacked. There's more depth in this unit than there has been throughout Fickell's tenure.

This unit's success may come down to the progression of homegrown edge defenders such as Nicolas Clayton and Jaylen Williams. If they elevate the rush behind senior Sebastian Cheeks, the Badgers figure to build upon a surprisingly good front last season.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Gavin Lahm redshirted last season in order to be eligible this season. He's shown a big leg as a kickoff specialist. Wisconsin hired a full-time special teams coordinator for the first time under Fickell, poaching veteran Bob Ligashesky from Minnesota. More coaching investment in the third phase should help a group that routinely uses starters on special teams. One area that must improve is punt returns. Wisconsin averaged 7.8 yards on 12 punt returns last season, opting for fair catches more often than not.

FINAL ANALYSIS The schedule breaks more favorably for Wisconsin this year than last, but there are too many new, unproven faces in key positions to predict a major turnaround for a program stuck in a rut. A better record should be in store, but the Badgers aren't yet contenders in the Big Ten.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-7 BIG TEN)

Aug. 28	Miami (Ohio)	W	17-0
Sept. 6	Middle Tennessee	W	42-10
Sept. 13	at Alabama	L	14-38
Sept. 20	Maryland	L	10-27
Oct. 4	at Michigan	L	10-24
Oct. 11	Iowa	L	0-37
Oct. 18	Ohio State	L	0-34
Oct. 25	at Oregon	L	7-21
Nov. 8	Washington	W	13-10
Nov. 15	at Indiana	L	7-31
Nov. 22	Illinois	W	27-10
Nov. 29	at Minnesota	L	7-17

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 6	vs. Notre Dame #
Sept. 12	Western Illinois
Sept. 19	Eastern Michigan
Sept. 26	at Penn State
Oct. 3	Michigan State
Oct. 17	at UCLA
Oct. 24	USC
Oct. 31	at Iowa
Nov. 7	Rutgers
Nov. 14	at Maryland
Nov. 21	at Purdue
Nov. 28	Minnesota

#Green Bay, WI

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Brady Bekkenhuis, IOL	★★★★
2.	Qwantavius Wiggins, RB	★★★★
3.	Keeyshawn Tabuteau, WR	★★★
4.	Djidjou Bah, DL	★★★
5.	Carsen Eloms, CB	★★★
6.	Jack Sievers, TE	★★★
7.	Ryan Hopkins, QB	★★★
8.	Yahya Gaad, EDGE	★★★
9.	Donovan Dunmore, CB	★★★
10.	Zion Legree, ATH	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Luke Fickell • Record at School: 17-21 (3+ years) • Career Record: 80-46 (10+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jeff Grimes • Defensive Coordinator: Mike Tressel • Location: Madison, Wis. • Stadium: Camp Randall Stadium (76,057)